



Colette's Home Bible

La Belle Maison



MAKE ANY ROOM LOOK EXPENSIVE
WITHOUT BUYING ANYTHING NEW

COLETTE DUBOIS

COLETTE'S HOME BIBLE

La Belle Maison — Make Any Room Look Expensive Without Buying Anything New

Written by Colette Dubois. Published by Chez Colette.

First edition.

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DISCLAIMER

This book is educational. It describes principles of light, colour, proportion and material, and how to apply them to an ordinary home. It is not professional advice, and it is not a substitute for a qualified tradesperson.

Nothing in this book asks you to carry out electrical, gas, plumbing or structural work. Where a correction touches any of those, you are told to stop and call someone licensed — and you should.

Some corrections involve drilling, ladders, and hand tools. Work within your own competence. If you rent, read your tenancy agreement before you make a permanent change to anything; a chapter of this book is devoted entirely to the corrections that need no permission.

If you suspect damp, mould, lead paint or asbestos in your home, this book will not help you with it and does not try to. Those are surveyors' and specialists' work, and the reasons are explained where they come up.

Every measurement is given in both metric and imperial. Where a price is mentioned it is an order of magnitude, not a quotation.

A NOTE ON THE PICTURES

This book is drawn, not photographed. Every diagram in it is a line drawing made for the page, because a photograph of somebody else's beautiful room teaches you nothing about your own. Any room described in an example is an example, written to make a principle concrete. None of them is a real client.

BEFORE WE START

A word from Colette

I grew up in a building that was never meant for people. It was built for looms.

The Croix-Rousse is the hill above Lyon where the silk weavers worked. Their Jacquard looms stood nearly four metres tall, so the buildings were put up with four-metre ceilings and enormous windows facing north, because north light does not move and does not glare and you can match a thread by it all day. The weavers are long gone. Ordinary families live in their workrooms now, and mine was one of them.

So I was raised being told which windows were the good ones. That is a strange thing to grow up knowing, and it turns out to be the most useful thing in this book.

My grandmother made curtains. Not as a hobby — as a trade, for forty-one years, in other people's apartments all over that city. Curtains, blinds, cushions, loose covers, upholstery. She saw the inside of hundreds of homes and she had hard opinions about every one of them. She kept a cloth-bound notebook of every window she ever measured: the drop, the width, the fullness, the colour she had mixed to go with it, and the name of the family. Near the end of her life she made me promise I would write it all down properly before it was lost.

This is me keeping that promise, with fourteen years of my own work added to hers.

Those fourteen years were not spent in beautiful houses. They were spent in small flats, rented flats, ground-floor rooms that never saw the sun, and apartments that a landlord had ruined with the cheapest white paint and the wrong lights. That is the work I know. If you are looking for a book about châteaux, this is not it.

I left the trade because it only knows one verb. *Buy*. A client would ask me why her sitting room felt wrong and the profession had trained me to answer with a shopping list. And most of the time the shopping list was not the answer. Most of the time the room was suffering three or four specific things that could be named, and two of them could be fixed before dinner with what was already in the flat.

That is the whole argument of this book, and I will say it once here and then spend two hundred pages proving it.

THE ARGUMENT

A room is not decorated. A room is corrected.

Your taste was never the problem. Nobody ever showed you what to look at. Let me show you.

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HOW TO USE IT

Read Part One first. It is short and everything else depends on it, because it teaches you what to look at. After that the book is a reference and you may take it in any order you like.

If you want to do something tonight, turn to **The Room Audit** on page 181. It is one page, it takes ten minutes, and it will tell you which part of the book to open.

If you are in the middle of a job and you just need a number — how high to hang a picture, how long a curtain should be, what size rug a sofa needs — go straight to **The Measurements** on page 165. Every figure in the book is collected there.

PART ONE

How to Read a Room

Before you change anything, you have to be able to see what is wrong. This part teaches you the four errors that ruin almost every ordinary room, the three questions that find them, and the order in which corrections have to be made if they are not going to waste your money.

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CHAPTER ONE

The room is not the problem

You have already tried. That is the part nobody credits you for.

You have moved the sofa. You have moved it back. You have bought cushions, and then different cushions. At some point you painted a wall, and it looked better for about a week, and then it went back to looking the way it looked before. You have a folder of saved photographs of rooms you like, and not one of them looks like yours, and you cannot say why.

So you have quietly arrived at the conclusion that the problem is you. That other people have an eye and you do not. That your room is simply an ordinary room and this is what an ordinary room looks like.

I have been in several hundred of these rooms. That is not what is happening.

What is happening is that you are being asked to solve a problem you have not been given the vocabulary for. Nobody taught you to look at a room the way a decorator looks at a room, which is not as a collection of objects but as a set of relationships — between the light and the wall, between the height of a thing and the height of your eye, between one material and the next. Without that vocabulary there is only one move available to you, and that move is to buy something. So you buy something, and it changes the objects in the room without changing any of the relationships, and the room looks the same.

And every single part of this industry is content for that to continue.

WHAT WE ARE ACTUALLY DOING

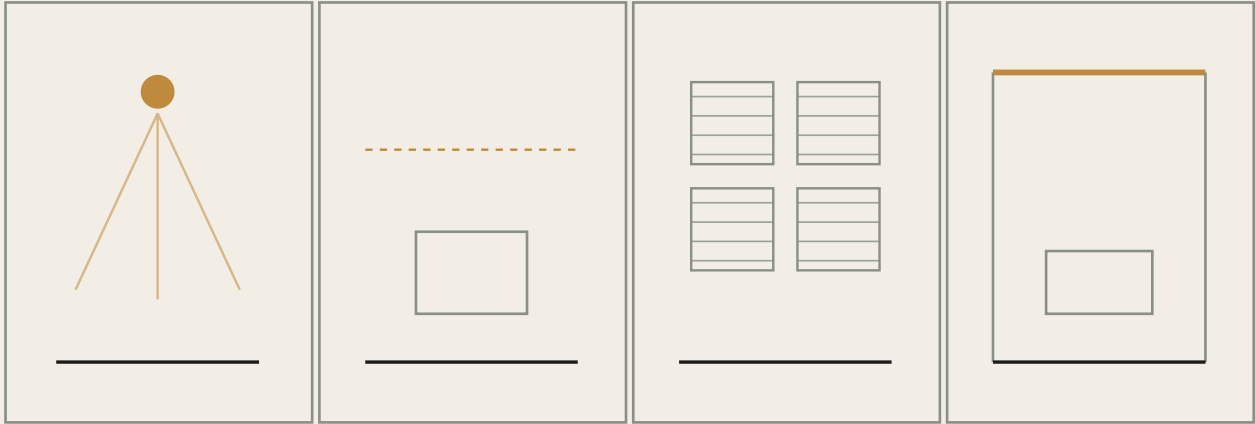
Almost no ordinary room is short of objects. Nearly all of them are suffering three or four specific, nameable errors.

Three or four. Not thirty. That is the good news buried in this, and it is the reason this book is possible at all. The errors repeat. They are the same errors, in flat after flat, in one country after another, and once you know their names you will see them in every room you walk into for the rest of your life — including on television, including in the photographs you saved.

Most of them cost nothing to correct. Some of them take twenty minutes. One or two are worth real money, and when we get to those I will tell you plainly.

The four errors

Here they are. Every one of them gets its own page after this, and every one of them gets a whole part of the book later on. For now, just learn the four names.



ONE · THE ROOM IS LIT FROM ONE HEIGHT

There is a light in the middle of the ceiling and that is all there is. Every object in the room is lit from the same angle, so nothing has any depth, and everyone in the room looks tired.

TWO · EVERYTHING IS HUNG TOO LOW

The pictures, the curtain pole, the mirror, the pendant. All of it sitting lower than it should, which drags the whole room down towards the floor and makes the ceiling feel closer than it is.

THREE · ONE TEXTURE, REPEATED

Everything in the room is the same kind of surface. Four soft things, or four shiny things, or four flat painted things. The room reads as a showroom, or as a waiting area, and you cannot say why because nothing in it is ugly.

FOUR · NOBODY HAS EVER LOOKED AT THE CEILING

It is the largest surface in the room. No furniture will ever hide any part of it. It is the last thing you see at night and the first thing you see in the morning. And you painted it white without once asking whether that was the right answer.

ERROR ONE

The room is lit from one height

Go and stand in your sitting room tonight with the lights on as you normally have them. Now look at the ceiling, and count the sources.

In most rooms the answer is one. There is a fitting in the middle of the ceiling, it is doing all of the work, and everything you own is being lit from directly above.

Here is why that single fact is doing so much damage.

Light from directly overhead falls on the top of everything and nothing else. The top of the sofa arm is bright, the front of it is not. The top of your head is bright and your eye sockets are in shadow, which is why everyone in a room lit this way looks exhausted. Nothing has a lit side and a shaded side, so nothing has any apparent depth — and a room without depth reads flat whatever you paid for the furniture in it.

And because that one fitting lights the whole room from one point, it has to be bright. So the brightness is the thing you notice, and the room feels like a place where tasks are performed rather than a place where anyone sits.

COLETTE'S RULE OF THE THREE HEIGHTS

Light must arrive at three heights — overhead, table, and floor. A room lit from one height is a room lit like a corridor.

This is my rule rather than a law of physics, and Part Two is entirely about it. But the correction is so cheap that I want you to have it now.

THE TWENTY-MINUTE VERSION

Tonight, turn the ceiling light off. Put two lamps on in the room instead — any two lamps you already own, one at roughly the height of a side table and one lower or taller than that — and put them in two different corners rather than side by side. Then sit down in the chair you actually sit in and look at the room.

Nothing bought, nothing moved more than a metre. And every object in that room now has a lit side and a shaded side, which is the whole difference between a room and a corridor.

IF YOU ONLY HAVE ONE LAMP

Use it, and turn the ceiling light off anyway. One lamp and a dark corner beats one ceiling fitting and no corner. The dark corner is not a failure — page 104.

ERROR TWO

Everything is hung too low

This is the most common error in this book and the cheapest one to correct, which is a combination you will not meet often.

Almost everything that hangs in an ordinary home hangs lower than it should. Pictures, mirrors, curtain poles, pendant lights, shelves, coat hooks. It happens for a reason that is completely understandable: you hang a thing at the height where it is comfortable to hold it up against the wall. That is roughly the height of your own hands at rest, and your hands at rest are a good deal lower than where the object needed to go.

Repeat that across nine or ten objects and the effect is cumulative. The whole visual weight of the room collects in a band about a metre off the floor, everything above that band is empty, and the empty part reads as unfinished while the crowded part reads as cluttered. Both at once, in the same room.

THE TWO NUMBERS THAT FIX MOST OF IT

A picture hangs with its centre at	145 cm · 57 in
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A curtain pole goes as close to the ceiling as it can, and the curtain drops to the floor	0–1 cm clearance
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One hundred and forty-five centimetres to the centre of the picture — not to the top, not to the bottom, and not to the hook. This is the standard hanging height used in galleries and museums, and the reason it works is that it puts the middle of the work at the eye level of an average standing adult. It is not a matter of taste. It is a matter of where human eyes are.

Go and measure one picture in your home right now. If the centre of it is at 120 or 125 centimetres, which it probably is, you have found one of your three or four errors, and the fix costs one nail hole and four minutes.

ONE HONEST EXCEPTION

Art hung above a sofa or a console follows the furniture, not the room — leave roughly 15 to 25 cm (6 to 10 in) between the top of the furniture and the bottom of the frame, and let that decide the height. Page 92 covers the whole business of hanging over furniture, including what to do when the two rules disagree.

Curtains are the larger prize and they get their own chapter, because moving a curtain pole upward by twenty centimetres does something to a room that is genuinely difficult to believe until you have seen it. The window appears taller. The ceiling appears higher. The wall stops looking like a wall with a hole in it.

ERROR THREE

One texture, repeated

This is the error that makes a room full of nice things feel like a hotel lobby.

Stand in the doorway and do not look at colour or at shape. Look only at *surface*. What is each thing in this room actually made of, and what would it feel like under your hand?

In a great many rooms the honest answer comes back as one material wearing four costumes. A grey fabric sofa, a grey fabric armchair, a grey fabric ottoman, and a grey fabric curtain: four soft things. Or: a glass table, a gloss-painted unit, a mirror, and a chrome lamp — four hard shiny things. Nothing in either room is ugly. Nothing is even badly chosen. And the room is lifeless, because a surface only reads as interesting next to a surface that is not like it.

A hand runs over linen and then over oak and then over unglazed clay and registers three completely different things. A hand that runs over four woven surfaces registers one thing, four times. Your eye does exactly the same arithmetic, faster, and without telling you.

COLETTE'S RULE OF THE FOURTH TEXTURE

A room reads as finished when four textures meet: something woven, something wooden, something ceramic or stone, and something living. Three is a showroom. Four is a home.

This is mine, and it is a rule of thumb rather than a truth — but I have used it for fourteen years and it has never once let me down in a room that was not working. Count the families. If you can only find two, you have found another of your errors, and it is almost always the cheapest one in the book to fix, because the missing family is usually clay or wood and both of those can be answered from a charity shop for the price of a coffee.

THE FOUR FAMILIES

FAMILY	READS AS	WHERE IT USUALLY IS ALREADY
Woven	soft, absorbs light	sofa, curtain, rug, cushion, throw
Wooden	warm, grained, matte	floor, table, frame, shelf, chair leg
Ceramic or stone	cool, dense, slightly rough	almost always the missing one
Living	irregular, moves	one plant, or branches in water

Metal and glass are not a fifth family so much as a seasoning. A room can carry a little and does not need any. If your room is all metal and glass, what it is missing is probably wood.

ERROR FOUR

Nobody has ever looked at the ceiling

In French we have a name for the ceiling that English does not have. We call it *le cinquième mur* — the fifth wall.

I did not understand what a good name that was until I started working in other people's homes and noticed that the ceiling was the only surface in the house that nobody had ever made a decision about. Every other surface had been considered. Somebody had chosen the floor. Somebody had chosen, or at least argued about, the colour of the walls. The ceiling was white because ceilings are white.

Consider what that surface actually is. It is the largest single uninterrupted plane in the room — larger than any wall, because no window or door is cut out of it. It is the only surface that no piece of furniture will ever stand in front of, which means you see all of it, all of the time. And it is the last thing you look at before you go to sleep and the first thing you look at when you wake up.

One coat of paint. Nobody sells it to you, because there is nothing in it for anyone.

THE LAW OF THE FIFTH WALL

The ceiling is the largest surface in the room, the only one no furniture will ever hide, and the only one you painted white without once asking why.

WHAT THE CEILING IS DOING TO YOUR ROOM RIGHT NOW

A pale ceiling appears to recede. A darker ceiling appears to come closer. That is a real perceptual effect and you can use it in either direction, which is the part almost nobody is told: a low ceiling is not automatically improved by white paint, and a very high ceiling in a small room is often improved by a darker one, because it brings the room down to a human scale and makes it feel occupied rather than echoing.

The choice depends on what the room is for and what is wrong with it, and Part Three gives you the whole decision. What I want from you here is smaller. I want you to go into the room you like least in your home, lie on the floor, and look up for thirty seconds.

Most people discover two things. The ceiling is not actually white any more — it has gone cream, or grey, or yellow near the light fitting. And there is more of it than they remembered.

HOW TO LOOK

The three questions

You now know the four errors by name. This is how you find which of them are in your room.

Do not do this from the doorway. Sit down in the chair you actually use, at the time of day you actually use the room, with the lights as you actually have them. A room that is being inspected is not the room you live in.

- 1 **Where is the light coming from, and how many places is it coming from?** Count the sources that are switched on. Then look at one solid object — a jug, a lamp base, the arm of a chair — and find its shadow. If it does not have one, the room has a single source and you have error one.
- 2 **Where is the highest thing on the wall, and where is my eye?** Sit still and look straight ahead without tilting your head. Note where your gaze lands on the far wall. Now look at the top edge of the highest picture, mirror or shelf. If everything on that wall sits below where you were already looking, you have error two.
- 3 **How many different materials can I count, and how many families do they belong to?** Not how many objects — how many *kinds of surface*. Woven, wooden, ceramic or stone, living. Fewer than three families is error three.

Then, last, look up. If you cannot remember making a decision about that surface, you have error four, and you have almost certainly got it, because almost everyone has.

WHAT YOU ARE LIKELY TO FIND

Three of the four. That is the ordinary result and it is not a disaster — it is why the room has been resisting you. Four separate problems, none of which is fixable by buying a cushion, and nobody ever told you their names.

DO NOT FIX ANYTHING YET

Write down what you found and put the pencil down. The order in which these get corrected matters a great deal, and doing them in the wrong order is how people spend money twice. That is the subject of page 15 and it is the most expensive page in this book to ignore.

The page opposite is the audit written out properly, with room to fill in. Photocopy it, or print that page on its own, and keep a filled copy for every room in the house.

WORKSHEET

The ten-minute room audit

Sat in the chair you use, at the hour you use it, with the lights as you normally have them.

ROOM

TIME OF DAY / DATE

ONE · LIGHT

SOURCES SWITCHED ON — HOW MANY

AT HOW MANY DIFFERENT HEIGHTS

☐ I picked one solid object and it has a visible shadow

TWO · HEIGHT

CENTRE HEIGHT OF THE MAIN PICTURE

GAP UNDER THE CURTAIN HEM

☐ Something on the wall is above my seated eye line

THREE · TEXTURE

☐ Woven — fabric, rug, weave

☐ Wooden — grained, matte

☐ Ceramic or stone — cool, dense

☐ Living — a plant, or branches in water

FOUR · THE FIFTH WALL

WHAT COLOUR IS THE CEILING ACTUALLY, LOOKING AT IT NOW

THE VERDICT

ERRORS FOUND, IN THE ORDER I WILL CORRECT THEM (SEE PAGE 15)

Why your room photographs badly when it looks fine to you

Nearly everyone has had this experience, and almost nobody knows what it means.

You stand in the room and it is perfectly pleasant. You take a photograph of it to send to somebody and the photograph is dreadful. The proportions look wrong, the colours look muddy, the whole thing looks cheaper than it does in life. So you conclude that you are bad at photography.

You are not. The camera is telling you the truth and your eye has been protecting you from it.

Your eye is not a camera. It moves constantly, it adjusts its exposure locally as it moves, and — this is the important part — your brain edits out what it already knows is there. You have not properly *seen* the cable behind the television for two years. Your visual system has decided it is not information and it stopped sending it to you. A camera has no such filter. It flattens the room to one plane, fixes one exposure for the whole frame, and reports back every single thing in it.

So the photograph is a free diagnosis. Use it that way.

HOW TO USE IT

Photograph the room, then look at the photograph rather than the room. The first three things that annoy you in the picture are the three errors you have stopped being able to see.

TWO REFINEMENTS THAT MAKE IT SHARPER

- **Turn the photograph upside down.** This is an old drawing-class trick and it works for exactly the same reason: inverted, the image stops being a room you recognise and becomes a pattern of shapes and tones. Errors of proportion and balance leap out. It is startling how well this works on a wall of pictures.
- **Turn it black and white.** With colour removed, what is left is the distribution of light and dark, and light and dark is what gives a room depth. A photograph that goes to uniform mid-grey is a photograph of a room lit from one height.

Keep those photographs. When you have finished correcting the room, take the same photograph from the same spot at the same hour. It is the only honest before-and-after there is, and it will show you things you did not know you had fixed.

THE MOST EXPENSIVE PAGE TO IGNORE

The order of operations

Corrections have to be made in a particular order, because each one changes the answer to the next.

This is the page that saves you money. Not because anything on it is difficult, but because the natural order — the order in which people actually do it — is almost exactly backwards, and doing it backwards means paying twice.

Here is the order. It goes from the thing that nothing depends on, to the thing that depends on everything.



- 1 **Clear.** Take out of the room everything that is broken, everything you do not like, and everything that is there because it has always been there. Do not replace any of it yet. An emptier room is easier to read, and a surprising number of rooms are substantially fixed at this stage. It costs nothing.
- 2 **Light.** Lamps, bulbs, heights, and what you can stop blocking. This comes before colour and it is not negotiable, for the reason on the next page. It is usually the cheapest real change in the room and almost always the largest.
- 3 **Height.** Curtain pole up, pictures to 145, shelves and mirrors adjusted. Nail holes and an afternoon. Do this before you paint, because you will be filling holes anyway and because the new heights change where the eye goes.
- 4 **Colour.** Walls, ceiling, woodwork. Only now, when you know what light the room will actually be living in.
- 5 **Texture.** The missing families. Fabric, wood, clay, something living. Last, because the right answer depends on everything above it.

THE EXPENSIVE MISTAKE

Buying furniture at any point in this list. Furniture is not a stage. It comes after all five, if it comes at all, and most of the rooms I have corrected needed none.

Why colour comes fourth and not first

Everybody starts with paint. It is the wrong place to start, and here is the reason in one sentence: a colour is not a property of the paint. It is what happens when that paint meets the light in your room.

Change the light and you have changed the colour. Not your perception of it — the actual wavelengths coming off that wall into your eye. The same tin of paint on a north-facing wall and a south-facing wall is two different colours, and anybody who has painted both will tell you so.

So when you choose a colour before you have settled the light, you are answering a question whose terms have not been set yet. Then you fix the lighting afterwards, and the colour you chose turns out to be wrong, and you paint again. I have watched people do this three times in the same room.

THE TWO THINGS THAT DECIDE A COLOUR BEFORE YOU HAVE CHOSEN IT

- **Which way the window faces.** North light in the northern hemisphere never carries direct sun; it is cool and steady all day, and it will push a warm grey towards blue. South light is warm and strong and will push a cool white towards yellow. This is the first page of Part Two and it is the single most useful fact in the book.
- **What your bulbs are.** A bulb has a colour temperature printed on the box and most people have never looked at it. Twenty-seven hundred kelvin is warm domestic light; four to five thousand is the light shops and offices are lit with. Put a colour chosen under one of those under the other and it is unrecognisable.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

“You are not choosing a colour. You are choosing what the light will do to it.” — my father was a house painter and he mixed his own colours, and this is the only thing he ever said about paint that I have never had cause to revise.

There is one more reason to leave paint until fourth, and it is the practical one. Paint is the most disruptive and least reversible thing on the list. You have to empty the room, cover the floor, and lose two days. Lamps take twenty minutes and can be undone. Curtain poles take an afternoon. It is simply better sense to exhaust the cheap reversible moves first — and a great many rooms never need the paint at all once the first three stages are done.

Everything you need to own

This is the complete list. It is short on purpose, and I would rather you questioned it than trusted it.

TOOL	WHAT IT IS FOR	ROUGHLY
A retractable tape measure , 5 m, metric and imperial on the same blade	Every number in this book. Nothing else in the list matters as much.	a few dollars
A pencil and a rubber	Marking a wall. Never a pen.	pennies
A small spirit level , 20–30 cm	Poles, shelves, rows of pictures. A phone app is not good enough for a two-metre pole.	under \$15
Low-tack masking tape	Marking heights on a wall before you commit to a hole. The most useful thing on this list after the tape measure.	a few dollars
Two large sheets of white paper , A2 or bigger	Testing paint properly. Page 54 explains why a small chip cannot tell you anything.	a few dollars
A drill , if you own the wall	Poles and heavy mirrors. Borrow one before you buy one.	borrow it

WHAT IS DELIBERATELY NOT ON THE LIST

No colour fan deck — you will be given the six whites that matter and the reason each one fails, and a fan of two thousand chips makes the decision harder rather than easier. No laser measure; a tape is more accurate at room distances and never needs a battery. No design software. No mood-board app. No subscription to anything.

THE ONE THING WORTH BORROWING RATHER THAN BUYING

A stepladder. You will need one for perhaps two afternoons in the whole of this book, and then it will live in a cupboard for a decade. Ask a neighbour. It is also how you find out whether your neighbour has a drill.

AND THE MASKING TAPE, BECAUSE I MEAN IT

Before you put a hole in anything, cut a piece of tape the width of the object and stick it on the wall at the height you are considering. Leave it there for a day. Walk past it. Sit down and look at it. Almost every hanging error in this book would be prevented by that one habit, and the tape costs less than the filler you would otherwise need.

What this book will not do

I would rather tell you now than have you find out on page 140.

IT WILL NOT MAKE A SMALL FLAT INTO A LARGE ONE

There are real techniques in here for making a small room read as larger and more deliberate, and they work. None of them adds a square metre. If your flat is too small for your life, that is a different problem and no book solves it.

IT WILL NOT HELP YOU WITH DAMP, MOULD, LEAD OR ASBESTOS

These come up in old buildings and they are not decorating problems. Damp has a cause and until the cause is found nothing you put on that wall will stay there. Paint in buildings from before the late 1970s may contain lead, and disturbing it by sanding is the dangerous part. Some materials in older buildings contain asbestos and must not be drilled or cut. If you suspect any of these, the correct next step is a surveyor or a licensed specialist, not a paintbrush. I will say so again each time it comes up.

IT WILL NOT DO ELECTRICAL, GAS, PLUMBING OR STRUCTURAL WORK

Nothing in this book asks you to. Where a correction would — moving a ceiling fitting, adding a socket, taking out anything that holds the building up — you are told to stop and call somebody licensed. There is more good work available to you without touching any of that than you will get through in a year.

IT CANNOT GET YOU PERMISSION

If you rent, some of this is not available to you, and Part Six is written entirely for that situation — every correction in it needs no drill, no paint and nobody's consent. If your building is listed or protected, check before you change a window, a door or anything on the outside.

IT IS NOT AGAINST SPENDING MONEY

This is the one people get wrong about me. I am against *wasted* money, which is a completely different position. There are things in this book I will tell you to spend on, because the cheap version is a false economy and you will buy it twice:

- A good lamp. It will outlive the room.
- Lined curtains, in enough fabric. The single largest visible difference money makes.
- A sofa whose cover can be taken off, or which can be reupholstered.
- Decent bulbs, which cost very little and change everything.

Everything else in the ordinary decorating budget is negotiable, and a good deal of it is listed on page 189 under the heading of what not to buy.

SIX THINGS YOU HAVE BEEN TOLD

That are wrong — part one

ONE · “PAINT A SMALL ROOM WHITE TO MAKE IT LOOK BIGGER”

This is the most repeated piece of advice in the subject and it is the one I disagree with most sharply. A small room painted flat white does not read as bigger. It reads as small and unfinished, because white shows you exactly where the walls are and there is nothing else for the eye to do. Meanwhile every mark, every radiator, every cable is on full display against it.

A small room painted a deep, quiet colour reads as *deliberate*. The corners soften, the walls stop announcing their distance, and the room feels like a decision rather than a shortage. This is my position and not a physical law, so I have marked it as mine — but Part Three gives you the whole argument and the cases where white genuinely is the right answer.

TWO · “GET THE BIGGEST LIGHT YOU CAN FOR A DARK ROOM”

A dark room is rarely short of lumens. It is short of *directions*. One very bright ceiling fitting in a dark room produces a bright ceiling and a dim room, because all it can do is illuminate the plane it is attached to and the tops of things. Three modest lamps at three heights will make that room feel twice as bright as one powerful pendant, using less electricity.

THREE · “PUSH THE FURNITURE AGAINST THE WALLS TO MAKE SPACE”

In a small room this is often exactly wrong. Furniture flat against every wall leaves a void in the middle, and a void does not read as space — it reads as a waiting room. Pulling a sofa five or ten centimetres off the wall, and letting one chair sit at an angle, gives the room an inside. The floor you lose is floor nobody was standing on.

WHY THESE PERSIST

Not one of the three is a conspiracy. They are all true of *showrooms*, which are lit from above, painted pale so the stock reads, and arranged around a central aisle. Advice written for a shop floor got repeated until it sounded like advice for a home.

That are wrong — part two

FOUR · “AN ACCENT WALL WILL TRANSFORM THE ROOM”

One wall in a different colour does not transform a room. It divides it. The eye reads the coloured wall as nearer than the others, so a room with one dark wall and three pale ones feels shorter in that direction, not deeper. If the wall you chose is the one with the window in it, you have also just put your only source of light in front of your darkest surface, which is the least useful arrangement available.

There is a version of this that works, and it is not an accent wall — it is taking one colour all the way round the room and onto the ceiling, so the room reads as a single volume. Page 66.

FIVE · “MIRRORS DOUBLE THE LIGHT”

A mirror reflects what is in front of it. That is the whole mechanism. A mirror opposite a window reflects the window and genuinely helps, because it puts a second bright rectangle into the room. A mirror opposite a blank wall reflects a blank wall, adds nothing, and has cost you the wall it is hanging on. Before you hang a mirror, stand where it will go and look at what you would be looking at.

SIX · “YOU NEED A FEATURE, A FOCAL POINT, A STATEMENT PIECE”

A room needs somewhere for the eye to rest, which is not the same thing and is usually cheaper. A window with the curtains hung properly is a focal point. A fireplace is a focal point. A bookcase with actual books in it is a focal point. The word *statement* is doing commercial work in that sentence, and the thing being stated is usually a price.

CARRY THIS ONE FORWARD

Almost every piece of decorating advice you have absorbed was written to sell something. Ask what each rule would have you buy, and a surprising number of them dissolve.

That is the end of Part One. You know the four errors, you know how to find them, and you know the order in which to correct them. Everything after this is detail, and the detail starts where it has to start.

PART TWO

Light

Light is the first correction and the largest one, and it is almost always the cheapest. This part covers what your windows are giving you, how to read a bulb box, the three heights a room has to be lit from, and what to do with a room that gets no sun at all.

Which way does your window face · 23

The three heights · 28

Colour temperature · 34

The room with no natural light · 39

The lighting plan · 42

CHAPTER TWO

Why light comes first

You cannot see anything in a room except light. Everything else you think you are looking at is light coming off a surface.

That sounds like a philosophical remark and it is in fact a completely practical one. The colour of your wall is light. The texture of your sofa is light — specifically, it is the pattern of tiny highlights and shadows across a weave, which is why velvet and linen look different even in the same colour. The apparent size of the room is light, because your eye judges depth largely from how brightness falls off across a surface.

Change the light and you have changed all three. Nothing else in decorating has that reach.

Which is why it is first, and why the money goes furthest here. Three good bulbs and a lamp you already own will do more for a room than a new rug at ten times the price. I have seen it happen in an afternoon more times than I can count, and it still surprises the person who lives there.

THE TWO HALVES OF THE PROBLEM

A room has daylight, which you did not choose and cannot change, and it has electric light, which you chose without thinking about it and can change tonight. They have to be handled differently.

- **Daylight** is a fixed fact of the building. What you can do is find out exactly what you have been given, stop wasting it, and choose colours that work with it rather than against it. That is the first six pages of this part.
- **Electric light** is entirely yours. Number of sources, their heights, the colour of the bulbs, whether they dim, what the shades do. Almost every error in the fourth error list lives here, and almost every one is correctable for under the price of a takeaway meal.

WHY I KNOW THIS

The building I grew up in was put up for silk looms, and the looms needed north light — light with no direct sun in it, that does not move across the day and does not glare, so a weaver could match a thread at nine in the morning and at four in the afternoon and get the same answer. Two hundred years later I am telling you the same thing about your sitting room. The weavers were right.

So we start with the window, because the window sets the terms for everything else.

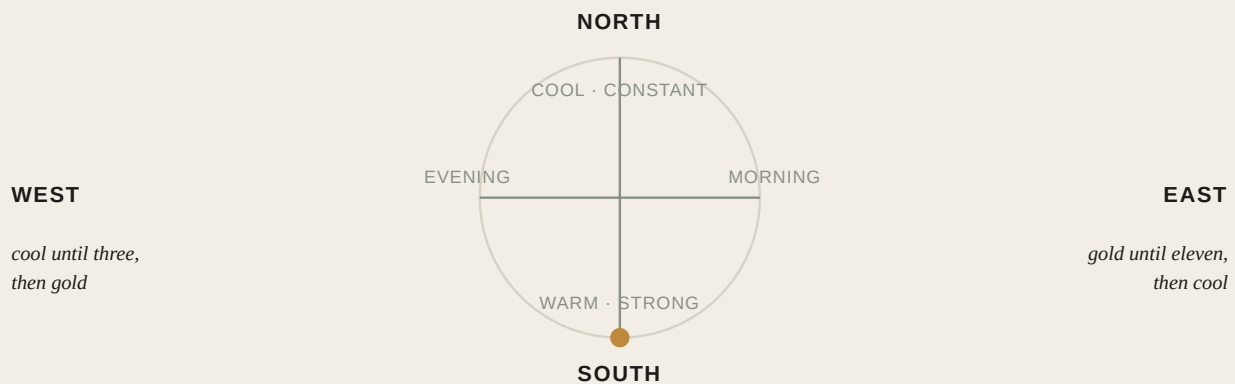
Which way does your window face?

If you take one thing from this book, take this. Almost nobody knows the answer for their own home, and every colour decision depends on it.

HOW TO FIND OUT, THREE WAYS

- 1 **The compass on your phone.** Stand at the window looking out. The bearing it shows is the direction the window faces. Thirty seconds, and it is the only thing your phone is better at than a tape measure.
- 2 **Midday.** In the northern hemisphere the sun is due south in the middle of the day. Stand at the window at noon. If the sun is in front of you, the window faces roughly south. Behind you, roughly north.
- 3 **Watch it for a day.** Direct sun in the early morning means east. Direct sun in the evening means west. Direct sun in the middle of the day means south. No direct sun at all, ever, at any hour, in any season — north.

Everything in this part and in Part Three assumes the northern hemisphere. If you are south of the equator, swap north and south throughout and leave east and west as they are.



Write the answer down for every room in the house. Put it on the audit sheet. You will use it on the paint page, on the bulb page, on the curtain page, and every time you are standing in a shop wondering whether a colour will work.

COLETTE'S FIRST LAW

Light before colour. You cannot choose a colour until you know which way the window faces.

NORTH-FACING

Cool, steady, and unfairly maligned

A north-facing room receives no direct sunlight at any point in the day or the year. Estate agents treat this as a defect. Painters and weavers have always treated it as the best light there is.

Both are right about different things. What north light is, precisely, is light from the whole dome of the sky rather than from the sun. That gives it two properties, and understanding them is the whole of managing a north room.

It does not move. There is no patch of sun crossing the floor, no hour when the room transforms, no glare. The light at nine is the light at four. This is why every proper painter's studio and every weaver's atelier in Europe faces north, and why my grandmother would only match a thread at a north window.

It is cool. Skylight is blue-biased, so everything in a north room is being lit by very slightly blue light, all day, forever.

WHAT THIS DOES TO YOUR COLOURS

It pushes them cold. A warm grey turns blue. A greige goes grey. A white with any blue in it goes clinical — and a great many fashionable whites have blue in them, which is exactly why they look so unpleasant in north rooms and so crisp in the showroom photograph that was taken in a south room.

WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT

- **Choose colours with warmth in them, and more warmth than you think.** A colour that looks slightly too yellow or too pink on the chip will look correct on the wall. Part Three gives you the specific whites.
- **Do not fight it with brightness.** Adding more cool light to a cool room makes it colder. Add warmth instead: 2700 K bulbs, and lamps rather than the ceiling.
- **Lean into it.** A north room will never be a sunny room, and a north room pretending to be sunny is the saddest thing in decorating. Deeper, warmer, quieter colours make it feel intentional. This is the room to be brave in.
- **Use the steadiness.** It is the one room in the house where a colour will look the same in the morning and the evening. If you have art you care about, or you sew, or you paint, this is where it goes.

THE TEST

Hold a sheet of plain white paper up in your north room at midday, then carry it to a south-facing window. The same sheet of paper. Most people are genuinely startled — and that difference is being applied to every surface in both rooms, permanently.

SOUTH-FACING

Warm, strong, and harder to handle than people expect

A south-facing room gets direct sun for most of the day. Everyone wants one. Nobody warns you that it is the most difficult light to decorate for.

The difficulty is that it changes. Direct sunlight is enormously stronger than skylight, and it arrives, crosses the room, and leaves. So a south room is really three rooms: a bright one in the morning, a blazing one at midday, and a normal one after the sun has moved past. A colour that is handsome at ten can be bleached to nothing at two.

It is also warm. Direct sun is yellow-biased, which means a south room flatters warm colours and can turn a cool colour muddy. And in summer it is a heat problem as much as a light problem.

WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT

- **You can afford cool colours here, and you generally should.** This is the room where a grey-green, a slate blue, or a proper cool white works — the sun supplies the warmth so the paint does not have to. In a south room, warm colours on top of warm light can tip into orange.
- **Test at the worst hour, not the best.** Judge a colour in a south room at full midday sun. If it survives that, it will be fine the rest of the day. Judge it at six in the evening and you will choose wrong.
- **Give yourself a way to soften the sun.** A sheer panel behind the main curtain, or a blind you can drop at midday, turns direct sun into diffused light without turning the room dark. This is what shutters do in Mediterranean buildings, and it is the single most useful thing you can add to a south room.
- **Expect fading, and plan for it.** Strong sun over years will lighten textiles, paper and some woods. Rotate cushions. Do not put a watercolour you love on the wall the sun crosses. This is not pessimism, it is just what ultraviolet does.

THE ONE THAT CATCHES PEOPLE

Gloss and satin finishes in a south room. Direct sun across a shiny wall shows every roller mark, every filled hole, every unevenness in the plaster, in a way that no other light does. In a strong south room, keep walls matte and save the sheen for woodwork.

EAST AND WEST-FACING

The rooms with two personalities

An east or west room has direct sun for part of the day and skylight for the rest. So it has two characters, and the decision you have to make is which one you are decorating for.

That decision is not a matter of taste. It is a matter of when you are in the room.

EAST

Direct sun from sunrise until late morning, then cool skylight for the rest of the day. The sun is low and the light is clear and slightly golden, and then at some point mid-morning it simply goes, and from then on the room behaves like a north room.

Decorate it for the afternoon, because the afternoon is most of the room's life. Which means treating it much like a north room: warmth in the colours, 2700 K bulbs, lamps for the evening. The morning sun will be a gift on top of that rather than something you have to accommodate.

Best use: kitchens and breakfast rooms, and bedrooms for people who like to wake with the light.

WEST

Cool skylight all morning, then direct sun from mid-afternoon until sunset — and evening sun is the warmest, most orange light of the day, arriving at a very low angle, straight into the room and straight into your eyes.

Decorate it for the evening if that is when you use it, which for a sitting room it usually is. West rooms can carry cooler colours than you would expect, because that evening light is so warm it will pull everything back. But you will need something to cut the glare — a sheer, a blind, a shutter.

Best use: sitting rooms and dining rooms, where the golden hour lands exactly when you want it.

IF YOUR ROOM HAS WINDOWS ON TWO SIDES

Then you are fortunate and you have a slightly more interesting problem. Cross-lit rooms are the easiest rooms in the world to make look good, because everything in them has a lit side and a shaded side without you doing anything at all — the two errors of flatness and of single direction are solved by the architecture.

Work out which window is dominant, by sitting in the room at the hour you use it and seeing which one is actually doing the lighting. Decorate for that one. Treat the second window as modelling light and do not block it, ever, with a piece of furniture or a plant.

WORKSHEET

What light do I actually have?

One row per room. Fill it in once and you will use it for years. The last column is the one that matters.

ROOM	FACES	DIRECT SUN, WHICH HOURS	WHEN I USE IT	DECORATE FOR

THE RULE FOR THE LAST COLUMN

IF IT FACES	THEN COLOURS WANT TO BE	AND BULBS WANT TO BE
North	warmer than you think — more yellow, more pink in them	2700 K
South	cooler — the sun supplies the warmth	2700 K
East, used mornings	can go cool	2700 K
East, used afternoons	treat as north — warmer	2700 K
West, used evenings	can go cool	2700 K
No window	see page 39	2700 K

You will notice the last column does not vary. That is not laziness; it is the conclusion of page 34, and it is the shortest chapter in this book.

ONE MORE COLUMN WORTH ADDING YOURSELF

What is outside the window. A brick wall two metres away, a large tree, a white-rendered building opposite — each of these changes the light reaching you more than the compass does. Green light off a tree in summer is a real and often unexplained reason a room's colours look wrong from May to September.

ELECTRIC LIGHT

The three heights

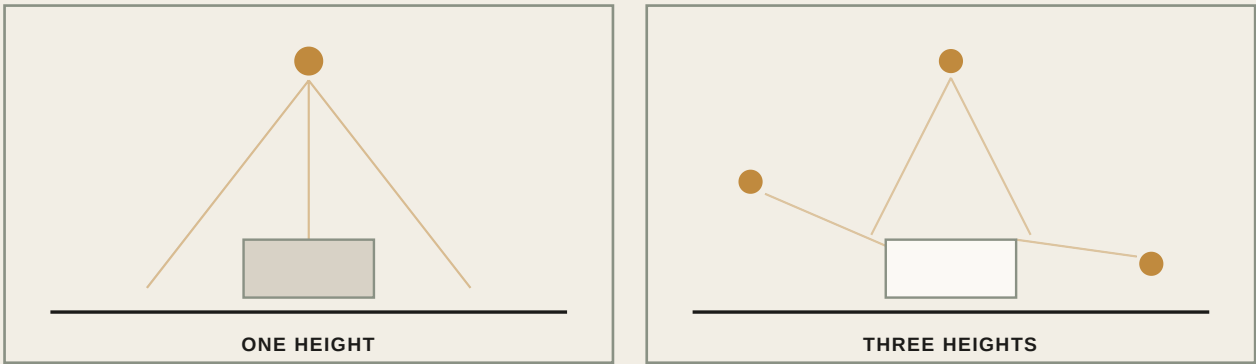
Here is the rule stated plainly, and then the reason, and then the numbers.

COLETTE’S RULE OF THE THREE HEIGHTS

Light must arrive at three heights — overhead, table, and floor. A room lit from one height is a room lit like a corridor.

This is mine and I will not dress it up as physics. But the reason underneath it is physics, and the reason is *modelling*. An object looks solid when one side of it is lit and another is not. That is the only cue your eye has for three-dimensionality in a still scene, and it requires light to arrive from more than one direction.

Put light at three different heights and every object in the room is caught from three angles. The jug has a bright side, a mid side and a shadow. The sofa arm has a top, a face and an underside. The room acquires depth, which is the quality people are describing when they say a room feels “warm” or “inviting” and cannot say why.



THE THREE, AND WHAT EACH ONE IS FOR

HEIGHT	ROUGHLY	ITS JOB
Overhead	ceiling	General fill. The least useful of the three, and the only one most rooms have.
Table	100–150 cm	The workhorse. Sits at seated eye level, lights faces kindly, gives the room its glow.
Floor	below 60 cm	Depth and atmosphere. Lights the bottom half of the room, which nothing else does.

Three sources, three heights, three switches. If you do nothing else in this book, do this.

HEIGHT ONE

Overhead, and what it is actually good for

I have spent a page telling you that the ceiling light is the problem. Now let me be fair to it, because there are three jobs it does that nothing else can.

- **Finding things.** You want a lot of even light when you are looking for a dropped earring or cleaning the room. That is a task, it lasts four minutes, and it is exactly what a ceiling fitting is for.
- **Safety.** Stairs, thresholds, anywhere someone might trip. Overhead light shows the edge of a step better than a lamp does.
- **Work.** A kitchen counter and a bathroom mirror need light from above and in front. In a kitchen this is not a compromise, it is correct.

What the ceiling light is *not* for is being the light you sit in. That is the whole error. It is a tool, not a setting, and the mistake is leaving the tool switched on all evening.

IF YOU ARE STUCK WITH A SINGLE CENTRAL FITTING

Most rented flats have exactly one, in the middle of the ceiling, and you cannot move it without an electrician. Three things you can do without touching the wiring:

- 1 **Change the shade so it throws light sideways and up, not straight down.** An open-topped drum or a fabric shade will bounce a good deal of its output off the ceiling, and light that has bounced off a surface is soft, directionless and much kinder than light straight from a bulb. This turns your worst fitting into something closer to indirect light, for the price of a shade.
- 2 **Reduce it and warm it.** Put in a lower-output 2700 K bulb than you think you need. You are no longer asking it to light the room; the lamps are doing that.
- 3 **Put it on a dimmer if the fitting and bulb allow.** See page 37 — and check that the bulb says dimmable, because most do not.

NEVER

A bare bulb in a ceiling fitting, in a room anybody sits in. It is the single harshest light source available in a home: a small, very bright point directly overhead, producing hard shadows in every eye socket in the room. If a shade is missing, a paper lantern costs almost nothing and is a genuine improvement, not a compromise.

One honest exception to all of this: a beautiful pendant, hung low over a dining table, is one of the great pleasures of a room. But look at what it is doing — hung low over a table it is no longer overhead light, it is table-height light with a cable. The height is the point.

HEIGHT TWO

Table height — the one that does the work

If you may only have one lamp, it goes here. This is the height that makes a room feel like somewhere people live.

The reason is that it is at the height of a seated person's eye. Light arriving from roughly your own eye level does two things at once: it lights faces from the front rather than the top, which is enormously more flattering, and it puts a bright object in your field of view without glaring, which reads as warmth.

THE NUMBER THAT MATTERS

Bottom of the shade, above the floor, for a lamp beside a chair or sofa	100–115 cm · 40–45 in
Which for a table at typical side-table height means a lamp of about	45–60 cm · 18–24 in
Bottom of the shade, for a lamp on a desk or console you stand at	125–135 cm · 49–53 in

The rule behind all three: **the bottom of the shade should sit at or just below the eye level of whoever is using the lamp.** Sit down in the chair and hold your hand at your eye. That is where the bottom edge of the shade wants to be. Higher and you are looking at the bulb. Much lower and the light pools on the table and never reaches your book.

This is why so many lamps are the wrong size — not the wrong style, the wrong *size*. A lamp is chosen in a shop, at standing height, on a display plinth. Then it goes onto a low side table beside a low sofa, and the shade ends up at chest height, and the room is lit from the chest up only.

HOW TO CHECK A LAMP BEFORE YOU BUY IT

Take two numbers with you: the height of the table it will stand on, and your own seated eye height (sit in a dining chair and have somebody measure from the floor to your eye — for most adults it lands between 110 and 125 cm). Table height plus lamp height to the bottom of the shade should land in that range. This is the only measurement anybody needs to buy a lamp, and no shop displays it.

WHERE THEY GO

Not side by side. Two lamps at table height on the same wall light one half of a room twice. Put them diagonally opposite, or at least on two different walls, so their light crosses. Two lamps on two walls is a lit room; two lamps on one wall is a lit wall.

HEIGHT THREE

Floor level — the one nobody does

This is the height that almost no ordinary home has, and it is the one that makes a room look like a photograph.

Think about where the light is in your room. It is all in the top half. Ceiling fitting at two and a half metres, perhaps a lamp at a metre. Everything below knee height is lit only by whatever falls down there, which is very little, because light falls off quickly with distance — double the distance from a source and you have a quarter of the light.

So the bottom third of the room sits in gloom, and because the bottom third of the room is where the floor is, the room reads as sitting in a dark pool. Adding a single low source transforms this, and it costs almost nothing because the fitting can be very modest.

FIVE WAYS TO DO IT, CHEAPEST FIRST

- 1 **A small lamp on the floor behind a chair or a plant.** Aimed up a wall or into the leaves. You cannot see the source, only the glow. This is the cheapest genuine transformation in the whole of this book — any small lamp you already own, put on the floor.
- 2 **A lamp on the lowest surface in the room.** A hearth, a stack of books, a low stool, the bottom shelf of a bookcase.
- 3 **An uplighter in a corner.** A canister that sits on the floor and throws light up the two walls of a corner. The corner glows, the ceiling picks it up, and the room gains a soft general light with no visible source.
- 4 **Candles.** Not a joke and not a decoration. A candle is a light source at table or floor height with the warmest colour temperature in the house, and four of them grouped is a real light. Never left unattended, never near a curtain.
- 5 **Lit shelving.** A strip tucked under a shelf, invisible, washing down the books below. The most expensive option here and the most permanent.

WHY IT WORKS

Light from below reverses every shadow in the room. Nothing else you can do in twenty minutes changes a room this much.

One caution, since the effect is strong: low light aimed at a face is theatrical and unflattering — it is how a horror film is lit. Aim it at a wall, a corner, a plant or a bookshelf, never across the seating.

How many lamps, and where they go

More than you have. Almost certainly more than you think is reasonable.

THE COUNT

Minimum separate light sources in any room anybody sits in	3
A sitting room, comfortably	4–6
Of which on the ceiling	1, off in the evening
Of which below 60 cm	at least 1

Five lamps in a sitting room sounds like a great many until you realise that each is small, dim and doing one job. Five modest sources use less electricity than one bright pendant trying to light the whole room, and the room will feel brighter. Brightness in a room is not the total output; it is how many surfaces have light on them.

WHERE THEY GO — THE FOUR RULES

- 1 Spread them around the perimeter, not the middle.** Light on the walls makes a room feel larger, because the walls are what define its size and a lit wall reads as further away. Light in the middle does the opposite.
- 2 Get one into every corner you can.** Dark corners make a room feel smaller and slightly unresolved. Not every corner — one should stay dark, see page 104 — but the others want something.
- 3 Put one where you sit and one where you look.** A lamp beside your chair for reading, and a lamp at the far end of the room so there is something lit to look towards. A room where all the light is behind you feels like a cinema.
- 4 Never point one at the television.** Or at a mirror, or at any glass, from opposite. You will spend the evening looking at the reflection of a bulb.

THE SWITCH PROBLEM, WHICH NOBODY MENTIONS

Five lamps means five switches in five awkward places, and a system you have to walk around the room to operate will be abandoned within a fortnight. Solve it before you build it: put lamps on a single switched extension where you can, or use plug adaptors you can control together. A lighting scheme that takes one action to turn on is a lighting scheme you will actually use, and that matters more than any individual fitting.

The numbers, collected

Every height in this chapter on one page, so you can take it to a shop.

WHAT	MEASURED TO	HEIGHT
Lamp beside a sofa or armchair	bottom of shade, from floor	100–115 cm / 40–45 in
Lamp on a desk or console	bottom of shade, from floor	125–135 cm / 49–53 in
Bedside lamp	bottom of shade, from floor	95–110 cm / 37–43 in
Floor lamp beside a chair	bottom of shade, from floor	115–130 cm / 45–51 in
Uplighter or low lamp	top of fitting, from floor	under 60 cm / 24 in
Pendant over a dining table	bottom of shade, above tabletop	75–90 cm / 30–35 in
Pendant over a kitchen island	bottom of shade, above worktop	70–80 cm / 28–32 in
Wall light in a corridor	centre of fitting, from floor	150–165 cm / 59–65 in
Wall lights either side of a mirror	centre of fitting, from floor	150–165 cm / 59–65 in
Bathroom mirror lighting	—	at the sides, not above

TWO RULES THAT EXPLAIN MOST OF THE TABLE

- **You should not be able to see the bulb from where you sit.** Every height above is really this rule expressed in centimetres for a particular piece of furniture. If you can see the bulb, the lamp is too high or you are too low.
- **Light a face from the side, not from above.** This is why a bathroom mirror wants lights beside it rather than over it — a fitting above a mirror puts your own eye sockets in shadow, which is why you look worse in a hotel bathroom than you do at home.

THE PENDANT OVER THE TABLE, BECAUSE IT GETS ARGUED ABOUT

Seventy-five to ninety centimetres above the tabletop looks far too low when the room is empty. It is correct when people are sitting down — it lights the food and the faces and not the ceiling, and you can see across the table underneath it. Hang it, then sit down before you judge it. Everyone who raises it wishes they had not.

THE NUMBER ON THE BOX

Colour temperature

There is a number on every bulb box that decides more about how your home feels than the price of your furniture, and most people have never read it.

It is printed in kelvin, with a capital K, and it describes the colour of the light rather than how much of it there is. The scale is confusing because it runs backwards from how you would expect: **a low number is warm and orange, a high number is cool and blue.**



THE WHOLE RECOMMENDATION

COLETTE'S RULE OF THE WARM BULB

Twenty-seven hundred kelvin, or nothing. Everything above three thousand is shop lighting, and a shop wants you to look at objects, not live among them.

Two thousand seven hundred kelvin is the colour of the old incandescent bulbs everybody grew up with, and it is the colour every human being alive associates with evening and with being at home. It is warm without being orange. It flatters skin. It makes wood look like wood.

Three thousand is acceptable and very slightly cooler; some people prefer it in a kitchen or bathroom. Four thousand belongs in a garage or a shop. Five thousand and up is sold as “daylight” and has no business in a room where anyone relaxes, because it tells the human body it is the middle of the day.

THE OTHER NUMBER WORTH FINDING

CRI, the colour rendering index, on a scale to one hundred. It measures how faithfully a light source shows colours compared with a reference light. A cheap bulb may sit around eighty, and under it your red cushion is a slightly brown cushion and your skin looks grey. Ninety or above is what you want, and it is often printed very small or as “CRI 90+”. It costs a little more and it is the difference between your colours working and not working after dark.

THE QUIET PART

Why every shop you buy from is lit wrong

Walk into any large homeware shop and look up. The light is cool, it is bright, and there is a great deal of it, coming from directly overhead across the whole ceiling.

Every single thing about that is the opposite of what this chapter has told you to do. And it is not a mistake. It is correct — for a shop.

Cool bright overhead light makes goods read clearly. It shows edges and colours at a glance, it reaches into every aisle without shadows anyone could trip in, it keeps people alert and moving, and it is cheap to run and easy to maintain at scale. A shop is a place where objects are examined. It is lit for examining objects.

Your sitting room is not a place where objects are examined. But here is the consequence, and it is worth sitting with for a moment:

Every purchase you have ever made for your home, you made under light that your home will never have.

You chose the grey of that sofa at four thousand kelvin from above. You will live with it at two thousand seven hundred from the side. Those are genuinely different colours. This is the real reason the cushion looked one way in the shop and another way at home, and why people assume they have been somehow deceived. Nobody deceived you. Two different lights.

AND THE ECONOMICS UNDERNEATH IT

Nobody decided this in a room somewhere. It is quieter and sadder than that.

There is no money in telling you the answer is a two-dollar bulb. There is a great deal of money in a shop floor arranged so that the object looks its absolute best under lighting conditions that you will never reproduce, and in the next purchase you make when the first one disappoints you at home. Nobody has to intend that for it to be how the whole thing works.

So the fix is not a boycott, it is a habit:

- Never make a final colour decision in a shop. Bring the sample home.
- Judge fabric and paint in the room they are going into, at the hour you use it, with your own lamps on.
- Change your bulbs before you change anything else, so that the light you are judging in is the light you will keep.

What to actually buy

This page is the cheapest correction in the book. An afternoon, a handful of bulbs, and the light in your home stops being wrong.

THE SPECIFICATION, EVERY TIME

- **2700 K.** Sometimes sold as “warm white”, but the words on the front vary between brands and the number does not. Find the number.
- **CRI 90 or above** if it is stated. If nothing is stated, assume it is not.
- **Dimmable**, if there is any chance the fitting is ever on a dimmer. It must say so explicitly.
- **The output you want, in lumens** — not watts. Watts describe how much electricity it uses, which used to be a rough proxy for brightness and is not any more.

LUMENS, ROUGHLY

FOR	LUMENS	OLD MONEY
A bedside or accent lamp	200–400	25–40 W
A table lamp doing real work	400–700	40–60 W
A reading lamp	700–900	60–75 W
A ceiling fitting in a sitting room	700–1000	60–75 W
A kitchen ceiling	1500–3000 total	—

Go lower than you expect on everything except the kitchen. The commonest error after colour temperature is buying bulbs that are far too bright, because the packaging competes on brightness.

AND THE SHAPE

Under a fabric shade, buy the cheapest thing that meets the specification above — nobody sees it. In an open fitting where the bulb shows, buy frosted or opal rather than clear: a visible filament is charming in a photograph and glaring in a room, because you are looking straight at a naked point source.

DO IT IN ONE GO

Walk round the house with a bag and count every socket, including the ones in fittings you never use. Buy them all at once, in the same specification, and change them in one afternoon. Mixed colour temperatures in one room is worse than either temperature alone — it is the only genuinely unfixable lighting error, because the eye cannot settle on a white point. If you do nothing else: make every bulb in a single room match.

Dimming, which matters more than brightness

A room needs different amounts of light at four in the afternoon and eleven at night. A room with one setting is wrong twice a day.

This is the part of lighting that people skip because it sounds like a luxury, and it is closer to a necessity. Your eye adapts: at eleven at night, with your pupils wide, the light you wanted at four in the afternoon is uncomfortably bright. And the amount of light in a room is one of the strongest signals your body uses to decide whether it is time to wind down.

FOUR WAYS, IN ORDER OF COST

- 1 **Separate switches.** The cheapest dimmer in the world is having five lamps on five plugs and turning two of them off. No wiring, no cost, and it is genuinely most of the benefit. Two lamps at eleven at night is a different room from five.
- 2 **An in-line dimmer on a lamp flex.** A small wheel that sits on the cable. Inexpensive, plugs in, nothing to install. The bulb must say dimmable.
- 3 **A plug-in dimmer or a smart plug.** Sits between the plug and the socket. Works with a remote or a phone. More expensive, no tools, and it lets you dim several lamps together.
- 4 **A wall dimmer.** Replaces the light switch. This is electrical work behind a faceplate and it needs an electrician — and if you rent, it needs permission. Do not do this one yourself.

THE DIMMABLE LED PROBLEM, WHICH CATCHES NEARLY EVERYONE

Most LED bulbs are *not* dimmable, and putting a non-dimmable LED on a dimmer gives you flicker, buzzing, a bulb that cuts out before the bottom of the range, or a shortened life. It has to say **dimmable** on the box. And even dimmable LEDs vary in how well they behave with any given dimmer, so if you are fitting several, buy one and try it before buying ten.

ONE THING BETTER THAN A DIMMER

A dimmed bulb gets dimmer but it does not get much warmer. Real evening light — a fire, a candle, a setting sun — gets warmer as it gets lower, and that is the quality a dimmer cannot reproduce on its own.

Which is why a candle or two, at the point in the evening when you have dimmed everything else, does something a dimmer cannot. It is not decoration. It is the only source in the house at around two thousand kelvin, and it is the reason a room with candles in it feels late in a way that a dimmed room does not.

What a shade actually does

A shade is not a decoration on a lamp. It is the part that decides where the light goes, and choosing it by appearance alone is how people end up with a lamp that does not light anything.

THE THREE BEHAVIOURS

SHADE	WHAT IT DOES WITH THE LIGHT	USE IT FOR
Opaque — card, metal, lined fabric	Sends light up and down in two cones. The shade itself stays dark.	Reading. Lighting a specific surface. Anywhere you want a pool rather than a glow.
Translucent — unlined linen, paper, parchment	Glow in every direction and lights the room generally. The shade becomes a soft object.	Atmosphere. The workhorse of a sitting room. Almost always the right answer at table height.
Directional — a hood, a cone, a spot	Sends light one way only.	A desk. A picture. Washing a wall. Never as the only light in a room.

COLOUR INSIDE THE SHADE

Look inside the shades you own. The inner surface is the last thing the light touches before it reaches you, and it tints everything.

- **White or off-white inside:** reflects efficiently, keeps the light neutral. The safe default.
- **Gold, brass or warm cream inside:** warms the light and increases the glow. Genuinely lovely in a north room and one of the oldest tricks there is.
- **Black or dark inside:** absorbs most of the light. Very dramatic, very inefficient. One in a room, never two.

THE PROPORTION RULE FOR A TABLE LAMP

Shade height, as a share of the whole lamp	about one third
Shade width at the bottom, compared with the base width	roughly twice
The shade must hide	the bulb and the fitting, from seated

That last line is the one that matters, and the first two are only rules of thumb that usually produce it. Sit down. If you can see the bulb or the metal collar it screws into, the shade is too small or too shallow, whatever the arithmetic says.

The room that gets no sun

A basement flat. A ground-floor room with a wall two metres away. A north room on a dark street. I have worked in a great many of these and I am not going to pretend they are the same as a room with a view.

Here is the honest position, and then what genuinely helps.

The honest position: a room with no useful daylight cannot be made to feel like a room with daylight. Every technique for “brightening” such a room is really a technique for making it feel intentional instead of deficient. That is a real and achievable goal, and it is a different goal from the one the magazines imply.

WHAT DOES NOT WORK, WHICH IS MOST OF THE USUAL ADVICE

- **Brilliant white.** The most common advice and the worst. White needs light to be white; without it, white goes grey and dead. You have painted the room the colour of the problem.
- **More lumens.** A dark room flooded with cool light becomes a lit dark room — gloomy and glaring at once.
- **A mirror on a blank wall.** It reflects the blank wall. Page 20.

WHAT WORKS

- 1 **Stop trying to be bright and commit to being warm.** This is the whole strategy. A deep, warm, enveloping colour in a sunless room reads as a decision — a study, a snug, a dining room for the evening. The same room in pale grey reads as a mistake. Deep green, warm brown-red, ink blue, a proper dark plaster colour. Be braver than feels sensible.
- 2 **Four or five small warm sources, none overhead,** with one dark corner left alone. You are building an evening room, so light it like an evening.
- 3 **Every texture you can find.** Texture is what gives a dark room something to do — light catching a coarse weave, a worn timber, a matte glaze. This is the room for the roughest, most tactile things you own.
- 4 **Something living, realistically.** A plant needs light too. Choose the tolerant ones and accept slow growth, or use branches in water and change them.
- 5 **Take back whatever daylight exists.** Page 41. Here every centimetre of glass matters, and it is usually half blocked.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

My grandmother made curtains for a dressmaker whose courtyard workroom never saw the sun. She lined its walls in a dark red and put six lamps in it. Everyone who came in said it was the loveliest room in the building. It was the darkest.

Corridors, landings and internal rooms

Nobody decorates a corridor and everybody walks through one several times an hour. It is the most neglected surface area in a home.

A corridor has a particular problem: it is long, narrow, usually windowless, and lit by one or two ceiling fittings that produce bright patches with gloom between them. So you walk down a tunnel of alternating light and dark, and the corridor feels longer and meaner than it is.

THE CORRECTION

- **Light the walls, not the floor.** Two or three wall lights along one side, centred around 150 to 165 cm, will do more than any number of ceiling fittings. Lit walls make a narrow space feel wider; a lit floor makes it feel like a route.
- **If you cannot add wiring, use the surfaces.** A small lamp on a narrow console, or a shelf at the far end with a lamp on it, gives you a lit destination. A corridor with something lit at the end of it stops being a tunnel.
- **Hang things at the right height, all the way along.** A corridor is the easiest place in the house to hang pictures, because you walk past rather than sitting, so the standard 145 cm centre is exactly right. A run of small pictures at a consistent height turns dead space into the best wall in the flat.
- **Do not paint it the same white as everything else.** A corridor is a transition and can take a stronger colour than a room you sit in, because you are only in it for four seconds. It is the cheapest place to be brave, because it is small and nobody lives in it.

INTERNAL ROOMS AND WINDOWLESS BATHROOMS

Treat these as the sunless room on page 39, with two additions. First, a windowless bathroom has a humidity problem as well as a light problem, and the extract fan matters more than anything decorative — if it does not clear the mirror within a few minutes of a shower, that is a ventilation job and worth sorting before you paint.

Second, these are the rooms where mirror placement is genuinely powerful, because a mirror opposite a lit wall or a lamp will double what little light there is and give the eye some depth. Put the light source and the mirror opposite each other, and stand where you will stand to check what you will be looking at.

BATHROOMS AND ELECTRICITY

Lighting and sockets in a bathroom are governed by specific rules about how close a fitting may be to water, and those rules exist for an extremely good reason. Anything beyond changing a bulb in an existing fitting is an electrician's job. There is no version of this where doing it yourself is sensible.

The daylight you are throwing away

Before you buy a single lamp, go and get back the light you already have. It is free, it takes an hour, and almost every home I have been in was wasting between a fifth and a third of it.

GO AND LOOK AT YOUR WINDOW. ALL OF IT.

- 1 **What is standing in front of it?** A tall plant, a lamp, a drying rack, a chair with coats on it, a stack of boxes that has been there since you moved in. Anything in the lower third of a window is taking light from the whole room.
- 2 **Where do the curtains sit when they are open?** This is the big one. In most homes the open curtains cover fifteen to twenty centimetres of glass down each side, because the pole is barely wider than the window. That is a tenth of your window, permanently, in every room, for years. The fix is a wider pole — it should extend 15 to 25 cm beyond the frame on each side so the curtains stack on the wall rather than on the glass.
- 3 **Is the blind fully up?** A roller blind left a third down is invisible to you after a week. Go and look. Roll it right up.
- 4 **Are the nets or sheers doing anything?** Permanent net curtains on a window that nobody can see into are costing you light for no reason. If privacy is only needed in the evening, a blind you drop is better than a sheer you never move.
- 5 **Is the glass clean, inside and out?** Unglamorous and genuinely significant on a window that has not been washed in a year or two, especially on a street.
- 6 **What colour is the reveal?** The little returns of wall at the sides of the window. If they are a dark colour, or grubby, they are absorbing light at the exact point it enters the room. Painting the reveal the palest thing in the room is a trick worth knowing.

WORTH SAYING ON ITS OWN

Most people's curtains, when open, cover a tenth of their window. Nobody notices, because the curtains have always been there.

Do all six of those before you spend anything. Then reassess the room. A surprising number of “dark” rooms are ordinary rooms with a blocked window, and you will have spent nothing.

WORKSHEET

The lighting plan for one room

One sheet per room. Fill the left column with what you have now, the right with what it should be.

ROOM		FACES / USED WHEN		
SOURCE	HEIGHT NOW	SHOULD BE	BULB NOW	SHOULD BE
Ceiling				2700 K
				2700 K
				2700 K
				2700 K
				2700 K

THE THREE CHECKS

- ☐ At least one source below 60 cm / 24 in
- ☐ At least one source between 100 and 135 cm / 40 and 53 in
- ☐ Every bulb in this room is the same colour temperature
- ☐ I cannot see a bulb from where I sit
- ☐ The ceiling light can be off and the room still works
- ☐ One corner is deliberately left dark

FREE LIGHT I AM CURRENTLY WASTING

- ☐ Nothing stands in front of the lower third of the window
- ☐ Open curtains stack on the wall, not on the glass
- ☐ Blinds go fully up; no nets on a window nobody overlooks
- ☐ Glass is clean, both sides

WHAT I WILL DO FIRST, AND WHAT IT COSTS

WHAT NOT TO BUY

Lighting

Six things this industry sells constantly that will not solve the problem you bought them for.

COLOUR-CHANGING SMART BULBS, FOR A SITTING ROOM

The colour-changing is not the problem; the problem is that they are usually bought *instead* of a second lamp. A single ceiling fitting that can turn pink is still a single ceiling fitting. If you want smart bulbs, put them in three lamps at three heights and you have something genuinely good. One is a novelty.

“DAYLIGHT” BULBS FOR A DARK ROOM

Sold specifically at the problem and it makes it worse. Five or six thousand kelvin in a room with no daylight gives you a cold blue room. The word on the box is doing the selling.

A BRIGHTER CEILING FITTING

The instinct when a room is gloomy, and it is treating a direction problem as a quantity problem. You will get a bright ceiling and the same gloomy room.

SPOTLIGHT TRACKS AND DOWNLIGHT GRIDS, RETROFITTED

Often sold as a modern fix for a dull room. What they produce is a ceiling of small bright sources all pointing straight down — error one, multiplied. They have real uses over a worktop or aimed at art. As general lighting for a room where people sit, they are the most expensive way to get a corridor.

VERY CHEAP MULTIPACKS OF BULBS

Where the colour temperature and the CRI are not printed, both are usually bad. Your colours will not work after dark and you will not know why. A bulb is the highest-leverage cheap thing in a house; buy the ones with the numbers on.

A DIMMER SWITCH, BEFORE YOU HAVE CHECKED YOUR BULBS

Fitting a dimmer to non-dimmable LEDs produces flicker and buzz, and people conclude the dimmer is faulty. Check the bulbs first. And a wall dimmer is electrical work behind a faceplate, which is an electrician's job.

WHAT TO BUY INSTEAD, IN ORDER

2700 K bulbs for the whole house. Then one lamp for the floor, if you do not already own something that will do. Then an in-line dimmer for the lamp you sit next to. That is a complete lighting correction for a room, and in most homes it comes to less than the cost of a single ceiling fitting.

Part Two, in nine lines

ONE

Light before colour. You cannot choose a colour until you know which way the window faces.

TWO

Light must arrive at three heights — overhead, table, floor. A room lit from one height is a room lit like a corridor.

THREE

Twenty-seven hundred kelvin, or nothing.

AND THE SIX THAT DO NOT NEED THEIR OWN PAGE

- **You should never see a bulb from where you sit.** Every height in this part is that one rule, measured for a particular piece of furniture.
- **Every bulb in one room must match.** Mixed colour temperatures is the only lighting error the eye cannot get used to.
- **Brightness is not output, it is how many surfaces have light on them.** Five small lamps beat one big pendant, and use less electricity.
- **Light the walls, not the middle.** Lit walls make a room read larger.
- **Get the free light back first.** Widen the pole, unblock the sill, raise the blind, wash the glass. Before you spend anything.
- **Never make a final colour decision in a shop.** You are standing under four thousand kelvin from above, and you will never live under it.

IF YOU DO EXACTLY ONE THING

Buy 2700 K bulbs for the whole house and change them all in one afternoon. It is the cheapest, fastest, largest single correction available to you, and everything in Part Three depends on it, because you are about to choose colours and you need to know what light they will be living in.

Turn the ceiling light off tonight and put on two lamps instead. That is Part Two. Everything else is detail.

PART THREE

Colour

Colour is the correction people reach for first and should make fourth. This part covers how to test a colour so it cannot surprise you, what an undertone is and how to see one, the six whites worth knowing, why a small pale room looks smaller, and what to do with the ceiling.

How to actually test a colour · 47

Undertone · 50

The six whites · 53

The small pale room · 57

The fifth wall · 61

Sheen · 67

CHAPTER THREE

Colour is not a property of paint

This is the sentence that makes the rest of this part make sense, so I am going to spend a page on it.

When you look at a painted wall, what reaches your eye is not the paint. It is light that has hit the paint and bounced off it, having lost the wavelengths the pigment absorbed. So the colour you see is the product of two things: what the paint absorbs, and what the light was made of before it arrived.

Change either one and the colour changes. Not your impression of it — the actual light entering your eye.

This is why the same tin produces two different colours on a north wall and a south wall in the same flat. It is why the colour you chose under the shop's lights is not the colour you have at home. And it is why so many people conclude they are bad at choosing colours, when what actually happened is that they chose correctly for a light they do not own.

THE FIRST LAW AGAIN, BECAUSE NOW YOU CAN SEE WHY

Light before colour. You cannot choose a colour until you know which way the window faces.

THE NAME FOR THIS, SINCE KNOWING IT HELPS

When two colours match under one light and stop matching under another, the effect is called **metamerism**. It is the reason a cushion and a wall that agreed in the shop can disagree in your sitting room, and it is not anybody's fault. Two different pigment mixes can reflect the same overall colour under one light source and separate completely under another.

You cannot prevent it. You can only ever judge a colour in the place and the light it will live in — which is the entire method of the next four pages.

WHAT THIS PART WILL AND WILL NOT DO

It will give you a way of testing colour that removes almost all of the risk, a working understanding of undertone, the handful of whites that are worth knowing by behaviour, and a clear position on ceilings, woodwork and sheen.

It will not give you a palette to copy. I do not know your windows, and anybody who offers you a colour scheme without knowing which way your room faces is selling you something.

How to actually test a colour

One method. It takes two days of waiting and about twenty minutes of work, and it is the difference between choosing a colour and gambling on one.

- 1 **Buy sample pots, not chips.** Two or three shortlisted colours. A chip is printed ink on card; a sample pot is the actual paint.
- 2 **Paint two large sheets of paper per colour, not the wall.** A2 or larger — the biggest cheap paper you can find. Two coats, edge to edge, and let it dry fully. Paper rather than wall for three reasons: you can move it, the colour underneath is not showing through, and you are not left with test patches to cover later.
- 3 **Leave a white border, or cut the sheet to size.** Colour is judged against whatever surrounds it. A patch of colour on an existing wall is being read against that wall and will look wrong in a way that tells you nothing.
- 4 **Move the sheets around the room and leave them for two days.** On the wall facing the window. On the wall opposite it. In the darkest corner. Beside the curtain. Next to the sofa. Tape them up and go about your life.
- 5 **Look at them at four moments** — morning, the middle of the day, dusk, and at night with only your own lamps on. A colour that survives all four is a colour you can commit to. Most shortlists lose a candidate at dusk.

WHY PAPER AND NOT THE WALL

A patch painted on a wall is being judged against the colour beside it. A sheet you can move is being judged against the room.

THE COST OF SKIPPING THIS

A sample pot and two sheets of paper cost a few dollars. Repainting a room because the colour was wrong costs a weekend, the paint, and the furniture moving — twice. I have never met anybody who regretted the two days.

Why a two-centimetre chip tells you nothing

Every paint brand hands you a fan of small printed rectangles and invites you to choose a wall from one. It cannot be done, and here are the four reasons.

ONE · IT IS INK, NOT PAINT

A printed chip is a reproduction. It has none of the paint's actual pigment, none of its finish, and none of the way real paint sits and scatters light on a surface. It is a photograph of a colour.

TWO · SCALE CHANGES WHAT YOU SEE

A colour covering a whole wall reads as considerably more saturated and usually darker than the same colour on a small card. This is partly the eye adapting and partly light bouncing between walls, each bounce deepening the colour. A colour that looks gentle on a chip can be startling at four square metres. **Choose one or two steps paler than the chip you liked.**

THREE · IT IS SURROUNDED BY OTHER COLOURS

On a fan deck your chip sits between two neighbours, and your eye reads it against them. Pull it out and lay it on white paper and it is a different colour. This is simultaneous contrast and you cannot switch it off; you can only control what surrounds the sample.

FOUR · YOU ARE LOOKING AT IT UNDER SHOP LIGHT

Which is roughly four thousand kelvin from overhead and has nothing to do with your home. Page 35.

THE ONE THING ON A PAINT CARD WORTH READING

Many brands print an **LRV** — Light Reflectance Value — a number from 0 to 100 describing how much light the colour bounces back, where 0 is a theoretical black and 100 a theoretical white. It is the single most useful figure on the card, because it predicts how a colour will behave in a dark room better than the colour itself does. Anything above about 70 is behaving as a pale colour. Below about 25 it is behaving as a dark one.

Use the chips to narrow fifty colours to three. Then stop using them and paint the paper.

Reading the sheets once they are up

You have three painted sheets taped around the room and two days have passed. This is how to read them, because most people look and cannot say what they are seeing.

ASK FOUR QUESTIONS, IN THIS ORDER

- 1 **At the darkest moment of the day, is it still a colour?** Look at dusk, before the lamps go on. Many pale colours collapse to grey at this hour. If it goes dead, it will be dead every evening of the year.
- 2 **In the brightest light it gets, does it go chalky or garish?** Direct sun on a pale colour can bleach it to nothing; direct sun on a saturated one can make it shout.
- 3 **Under your own lamps at night, has it changed hue?** Not just darkened — changed. Greens go grey, greys go lilac, whites go yellow. This is the test that catches the most mistakes, and it is the one nobody runs.
- 4 **Against the things that are staying in the room** — the floor, the sofa, the curtain, the door — does it sit comfortably or does one of them start to look wrong? Move the sheet next to each in turn.

WHAT A GOOD ANSWER LOOKS LIKE

The colour you want is the one that is slightly less interesting than its rivals at every hour, and never actively wrong at any of them. Colours that are thrilling at one particular moment are usually exhausting to live with, because the other twenty-three hours are the compromise.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

My father used to say that the colour you notice is the colour you will get tired of. He chose for the light, not for the card, and he always looked at a colour last thing at night before he would agree to mix a full tin of it.

IF TWO SURVIVE

Take the paler one. Every colour goes a little deeper once it covers a whole room and the light starts bouncing between the walls, and almost nobody in the history of decorating has wished their walls were darker after the second coat.

Undertone, and why nobody explains it

This is the concept that separates people who can choose colours from people who cannot, and it is usually described so vaguely that it sounds like intuition. It is not. It is a simple thing.

Almost no paint colour is pure. A grey is never only grey; there is a little blue in it, or a little green, or a little violet, or a little brown. That trace is the **undertone**, and it is what the colour reveals when it is put next to something else or lit by something else.

You can ignore a colour's undertone right up until the moment it meets another colour. Then it is the only thing that matters. A grey with a blue undertone beside a grey with a green undertone will look dirty, and neither is a bad colour. They simply disagree.

WHY THIS RUINS SO MANY ROOMS

Because most rooms are not one colour. They are a wall colour, a ceiling white, a woodwork white, a floor, a sofa and a curtain — six things, each with an undertone, chosen at different times by different logics. If four of them lean warm and two lean cool, the room will feel subtly wrong and nobody will be able to say why. Everything in it is perfectly nice.

THE PRACTICAL RULE

You do not need to know which undertone a room has. You need all of them to be the same one.

THE SHORTCUT, IF YOU TAKE NOTHING ELSE FROM THIS PAGE

Decide once, for the whole flat, whether you are warm or cool. Then choose everything on that side — the whites, the greys, the timber, the metals. A consistently warm room and a consistently cool room are both beautiful. A room that is half of each is the one that reads as cheap.

Which one should you pick? Look at what you cannot change. The floor, usually. A honey oak floor has decided that your flat is warm, whatever you were planning. Fighting the largest surface in the room is a losing argument.

How to see an undertone

You cannot see an undertone by staring at a colour on its own. You can only see it by comparison, and once you know the trick you will never lose it.

THE WHITE PAPER TEST

Take a sheet of ordinary printer paper — which is a very cool, very bright white — and hold your sample against it.

- If the sample suddenly looks yellow, pink or brown, it is **warm**.
- If it looks blue, grey or slightly violet, it is **cool**.
- If it looks green, it is green, and greens behave as their own family — see below.

That is the whole test. It takes four seconds and it works on paint, fabric, tile and timber equally.

THE THREE-SAMPLE TEST, WHICH IS BETTER

Put your candidate between two colours you already know. If you have a warm white and a cool white to hand, lay the sample between them. The one it resembles is the side it is on. This is more reliable than the paper test because it gives your eye two references instead of one.

THE UNDERTONES YOU WILL MEET MOST OFTEN

FAMILY	WARM VERSION LEANS	COOL VERSION LEANS
White	cream, yellow, a little pink	blue, grey, violet
Grey	brown — a “greige”	blue or violet
Green	olive, moss, yellow-green	sage, teal, blue-green
Beige	orange, gold	pink, mauve — the classic trap
Timber	oak, cherry, walnut	ash, limed oak, grey-washed

THE BEIGE TRAP, SINCE IT CATCHES EVERYONE

Beiges and taupes are the hardest colours in the shop, because a great many of them have a pink or mauve undertone that is invisible on a chip and unmistakable on a wall in afternoon light. If you are considering a beige, run the paper test twice — once in daylight and once under a lamp — before you buy anything.

There is no such thing as white

Every paint brand sells between forty and a hundred whites. That is not cynicism. It is because white is not a colour but a whole family of them, and the differences are the entire point.

A white paint is a white pigment with a small amount of something else added. What that something else is decides everything about how the colour behaves on your wall.

THE THREE THINGS THAT DIFFER BETWEEN WHITES

- **The undertone.** Yellow, red, blue, green or grey, in a very small quantity. This is what decides whether your room feels warm or cold.
- **How much of it there is.** A white with a trace of yellow is a warm white; a white with a good deal of yellow is cream, which behaves as a colour and not as a white.
- **Whether any black or grey has been added.** A white knocked back with grey is softer, less reflective, and much easier to live with than a brilliant white — and most of the whites that decorators use are of this kind.

THE ONE TO BE CAREFUL OF

Most brands sell a **brilliant white** or **pure white** which has optical brighteners in it, making it the coldest and most reflective thing you can put on a wall. It is designed to read as clean and it does. It is also unforgiving: it shows every flaw in the plaster, it goes blue in a north room, and it makes everything you put against it look slightly grubby, including other whites.

It has real uses — a gallery, a workshop, a ceiling in a room that needs every photon it can get. It is almost never the right white for a room where people sit.

IF YOU REMEMBER ONE THING ABOUT WHITE

A white with a little grey in it looks expensive. A brilliant white looks like a rental.

That is a judgement rather than a fact, and it is one I will defend. Brilliant white is what a landlord reaches for because it is cheap, fast and neutral to every future tenant. Your eye has learned that association, and it applies it to your own walls.

THE SIX WHITES

Described by behaviour, not by brand

I am not going to give you product names, because they change, they differ by country, and a name tells you nothing about what a colour will do in your room. I am going to describe six whites by how they behave. Every brand sells all six.

ONE · BRILLIANT WHITE

No undertone, often optically brightened. LRV near 90 or above.

The coldest and most reflective. Shows every imperfection. Goes blue in north light. Makes adjacent whites look dirty.

Use it for: a ceiling in a genuinely dark room where reflectance matters more than warmth. A workshop. Almost nothing else.

TWO · SOFT WHITE — WHITE WITH A LITTLE GREY

Grey undertone, LRV roughly 80 to 88.

The most useful white there is. Reads as white but has enough body to stop it glaring, and it is forgiving of imperfect plaster. Works in more rooms than anything else in this list.

Use it for: walls in almost any room, ceilings in most rooms, and woodwork if you want it quiet. If you cannot decide, this is the answer.

THREE · WARM WHITE — WHITE WITH A LITTLE YELLOW

Yellow undertone, LRV roughly 80 to 88.

Gentle, slightly sunny, flatters skin and timber. In strong south light it can tip towards cream, which some people love and some find dated.

Use it for: north-facing rooms, which need the warmth; rooms with honey or oak floors; bedrooms.

READING THE NUMBERS

LRV figures here are the ordinary ranges these whites fall into, not a rule. Use them to compare candidates on the same card: a white at 84 will behave noticeably differently in a dark room from one at 74, and the number will tell you that before your eye does.

The six whites, continued

FOUR · COOL WHITE — WHITE WITH A LITTLE BLUE OR VIOLET

Blue undertone, LRV roughly 80 to 88.

Crisp and slightly austere. In a south-facing room it is genuinely beautiful, because the warm sunlight cancels the blue and leaves something very clean. In a north-facing room it is bleak.

Use it for: south and west rooms, bathrooms, kitchens with a lot of daylight. Never a north room.

FIVE · GREIGE — WHITE KNOCKED WELL BACK WITH WARM GREY

Brown-grey undertone, LRV roughly 60 to 75.

No longer really a white; it is a very pale colour. Reads as soft, quiet and slightly expensive, and it is extremely forgiving of poor light and poor plaster.

Use it for: the room you cannot make work. Hallways, north rooms, rooms with a lot of mismatched furniture that needs calming down.

SIX · CREAM — WHITE WITH A GOOD DEAL OF YELLOW

Strong yellow undertone, LRV roughly 70 to 84.

Behaves as a colour, not a white. Warm, soft, and strongly associated with older interiors; whether that reads as handsome or dated depends entirely on what you put with it. It is unbeatable against dark timber, old brass and worn stone.

Use it for: period rooms, rooms with substantial woodwork, anywhere with an open fire.

THE MOST COMMON WHITE MISTAKE

Using two different whites in the same room without meaning to — a cool white on the ceiling and a warm white on the walls, or trade white on the woodwork and something chosen on the walls. The eye reads the mismatch as dirt rather than as a decision. Either use one white throughout, or make the difference large enough to be obviously deliberate.

Which white for which room

The whole of the last three pages, reduced to a table you can take to the shop. Find your room's orientation on the left.

ROOM FACES	CHOOSE	AVOID	BECAUSE
North	Warm white · Greige · Cream	Cool white · Brilliant white	The light is blue all day and will drain anything cool. Warmth in the paint replaces warmth the window cannot give.
South	Cool white · Soft white	Cream · strong warm white	The sun supplies the warmth. A warm white under warm light tips into yellow.
East used mornings	Soft white · Cool white	Cream	Morning sun is clear and slightly golden; the room can take something crisper.
East used afternoons	Warm white · Greige	Cool white	After mid-morning it behaves exactly like a north room. Treat it as one.
West	Soft white · Cool white	Cream	Cool all morning, then very warm evening light pulls everything back. Cool paint is safe here.
No window	None of them — see page 39	all whites	White needs light to be white. Without it, go warm and deep instead.

TWO NOTES ON USING THIS TABLE

It is a starting point, not a verdict. It narrows a hundred whites to about a dozen. You still paint the sheets and you still look at them at dusk.

What is outside the window can override it. A large tree throws green light into a room for half the year. A red brick wall two metres away throws warm light in all year. If either is true of your room, test more carefully than the table suggests.

Where white fails

White is the default, which means it is chosen far more often than it is decided. Here are the five rooms where it is the wrong answer, and what to do instead.

ONE · THE ROOM WITH NO DAYLIGHT

Covered on page 39 and worth repeating here: white needs light to be white. In a sunless room it goes grey and dead, and a grey dead room announces what it is missing. Go warm and deep instead.

TWO · THE SMALL ROOM YOU WANT TO FEEL FINISHED

See the next page, which argues this one out properly.

THREE · THE ROOM WITH BAD PLASTER

White, and especially brilliant white, is the least forgiving finish there is. Every ripple, patch and filled hole reads. A colour with some depth in it, in a matt finish, hides a surprising amount. If your walls are old and uneven, paint is doing repair work as well as decoration.

FOUR · THE TRANSITIONAL SPACE

Hallways, landings, corridors, cloakrooms. You are in them for seconds, so they can carry a much stronger colour than a room you sit in — and because they are small and dark they tend to make white look grubby. This is the cheapest place in the house to be brave.

FIVE · THE ROOM THAT IS ALREADY FULL OF WHITE THINGS

A white kitchen with white units, white tiles and white appliances does not need white walls as well. At some point the room stops reading as clean and starts reading as unresolved, because there is nothing for the eye to measure the whites against.

THE TEST

Ask whether you chose white or defaulted to it. If you cannot say what the alternative was, you defaulted.

None of which is an argument against white. Half the rooms I have worked in ended up white, and page 55 exists because choosing the right one matters. It is an argument against white as a way of avoiding the decision.

MY MOST UNPOPULAR POSITION

A small room painted pale looks smaller

I want to mark this clearly: this is my professional opinion and not a law of physics. It is also the piece of advice I have most often been argued with about, and most often been thanked for later.

The standard advice is that pale colours make a small room feel larger. The reasoning is that pale walls reflect more light, and a brighter room reads as bigger. The first half of that is true — a high-LRV colour genuinely does bounce more light. The conclusion does not follow.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS IN A SMALL PALE ROOM

- **You can see exactly where the walls are.** A pale wall is legible. Every corner, every junction, every edge is clearly drawn, and your eye measures the room accurately — which in a small room is not what you want.
- **Every flaw is on display.** The radiator, the cables, the patched plaster, the mismatched skirting. In a small room these are close to you and there is nowhere for them to hide.
- **It reads as unfinished.** Because the association is with rooms that have not been decided about: rentals, new builds before anyone moves in, rooms between tenants.

WHAT HAPPENS IN A SMALL DARK ROOM

The corners soften and the eye loses the exact edges of the space, so the room stops announcing its dimensions. The flaws recede. And most importantly it reads as *deliberate* — nobody paints a room deep green by accident, so the room is immediately understood as a choice rather than a shortage.

COLETTE'S RULE OF THE SMALL PALE ROOM

A small room painted pale does not look bigger. It looks small and cheap. A small room painted deep looks deliberate.

WHERE I CONCEDE

If the small room is also the only room, and you are in it all day, and it has one small window, a deep colour can genuinely be oppressive. And if you are selling the flat, pale is the commercially safe answer, because buyers are told the same advice I am arguing with. Both of those are real. Neither is about how the room looks.

What a deep colour actually does

If you are going to take the argument on the last page seriously, you need to know what you are buying. Four things happen, and the third surprises people.

ONE · THE EDGES OF THE ROOM STOP BEING LEGIBLE

In a dark room, the corner where two walls meet carries very little contrast, so your eye cannot place it precisely. The room's boundary becomes approximate. This is the whole mechanism behind “it feels bigger”, and it is the opposite of the reason usually given.

TWO · EVERYTHING IN FRONT OF THE WALL GAINS CONTRAST

A pale lamp against a dark wall has enormous presence. A picture frame reads. A plant reads. A face reads. In a pale room all of these are competing with a bright background and lose; in a dark room they are lit objects against a quiet ground, which is how a painting is hung in a gallery and why it works.

THREE · THE LIGHTING STARTS DOING MUCH MORE WORK

This is the one people are not warned about. A dark room absorbs light rather than bouncing it, so a single ceiling fitting will not carry it — the room will simply be gloomy. Deep colour and the three heights from Part Two are a package. If you paint a room dark and light it from one point, you will hate it, and you will blame the colour.

FOUR · THE ROOM ACQUIRES A TIME OF DAY

A dark room is at its best in the evening, under lamps, and is frankly a little sombre at ten in the morning. That is fine for a sitting room, a dining room or a study. It is a real consideration for a room you work in all day.

BEFORE YOU COMMIT

Paint the sheets, as always, but for a deep colour paint *four* and put them on all four walls at once, because a dark colour on one wall of a pale room tells you nothing about a dark room. And check page 61 first: in most cases a deep colour wants the ceiling and woodwork to go with it, and that changes the size of the job.

How dark is dark enough

The commonest failure with a deep colour is not going far enough. A mid-tone is the one place you genuinely should not stop.

There are broadly three places a wall colour can sit, and the middle one is the trap.

ROUGHLY	READS AS	VERDICT
LRV 70–90	Pale. The wall is a background and stays quiet.	Works. Commits to being light.
LRV 35–70	Mid-tone. Too dark to disappear, too pale to enclose.	The trap. Often reads as a colour that was meant to be braver.
LRV under 25	Deep. The wall recedes and becomes a ground.	Works. Commits to being dark.

These bands are a working guide rather than a standard, and the boundaries are soft — a saturated mid-tone in a well-lit room can be excellent. But if you find yourself choosing a colour because it seems like a sensible compromise between pale and dark, that is usually the signal to go one way or the other.

WHY THE MIDDLE FAILS

Because both mechanisms need commitment. A pale colour works by reflecting light and staying out of the way; a deep colour works by absorbing light and softening the edges. A mid-tone does neither. It is bright enough that you still read every corner, and dark enough that the room is noticeably dimmer. You have paid the cost of the dark room and bought none of the benefit.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

A client in Lyon asked my grandmother what colour to paint a small dining room. She said: either a colour you could read a book against, or a colour you could not. Anything in between and you will repaint it within two years. She was right about that woman, who repainted it within two years.

THE PRACTICAL VERSION

Choose your candidate. Then find the version of it two or three steps darker on the same strip and test that one too. Nine times out of ten the darker one is the answer.

WORKSHEET

Choosing a colour for one room

Fill the top before you go shopping. Fill the bottom after the sheets have been up for two days.

ROOM

FACES / USED WHEN

WARM OR COOL (DECIDED BY THE FLOOR)

WHAT IS OUTSIDE THE WINDOW

THE THREE CANDIDATES

COLOUR

LRV

UNDERTONE (PAPER
TEST)

WARM / COOL

THE FOUR VIEWINGS

MORNING

MIDDAY

DUSK

LAMPS ONLY

Candidate 1

Candidate 2

Candidate 3

THE CHECKS

- ☐ Painted on paper, two coats, not on the wall
- ☐ Moved to at least three positions in the room
- ☐ Held against the floor, the sofa and the curtain
- ☐ Still a colour at dusk, before the lamps go on
- ☐ Has not changed hue under my own lamps at night
- ☐ Same undertone as everything else staying in the room

CHOSEN — AND ONE SENTENCE ON WHY

THE FIFTH WALL

What to do with a ceiling

You met *le cinquième mur* on page 11. Here is the decision, and there are only three answers.

ONE · A WHITE, BUT CHOSEN RATHER THAN ASSUMED

The default, and correct more often than not — but not brilliant white, and not a different white from the walls. The usual best answer is **the wall colour mixed with white at about a quarter strength**, which most merchants will do for you. It reads as white, it belongs to the room, and the junction where wall meets ceiling stops being a hard line.

TWO · THE SAME COLOUR AS THE WALLS

Wall colour taken straight across the ceiling. This is the one that surprises people, and in the right room it is the best thing in this part of the book. What it does is remove the boundary between wall and ceiling, so the room reads as a single volume rather than a box with a lid.

Best in: small rooms, rooms with awkward angles or sloping ceilings, box rooms, and any room you want to feel enclosing rather than tall. It is also the answer to a ceiling covered in pipework or patches, because it stops advertising them.

THREE · DARKER THAN THE WALLS

A deliberate move for a room with a high ceiling that feels cold or cavernous. A darker ceiling appears to come closer, which brings a tall room down to a human scale.

Best in: high-ceilinged period rooms — a Haussmannian apartment runs between two point eight and three point two metres, and a room like that can carry a dark ceiling easily. A dining room. Anywhere you want the evening to feel intimate.

THE ONE THING NOT TO DO

Leave the old brilliant white ceiling in place while painting the walls a considered colour. It is the most common half-finished job there is: a careful colour on four surfaces and a cold builder's white on the fifth, meeting it in a hard line all the way round the room. Whatever you choose, choose it.

One colour, everywhere

Walls, ceiling, woodwork, skirting, door, window frame — all in the same colour. It sounds extreme. It is the single most reliable way to make an ordinary room look considered.

WHY IT WORKS

Every junction in a room is a place where the eye stops: wall to ceiling, wall to skirting, wall to architrave, architrave to door. An ordinary room has dozens, and each one is drawn in high contrast because the woodwork is white and the wall is not. Your eye spends the whole time tracing an outline of the room's plumbing.

Take the contrast out of those junctions and they stop being events. What is left is a single quiet volume with your furniture in it — and the furniture, the art and the people become the things you look at, because they are now the only things with contrast in the room.

WHERE IT EARNS ITS KEEP MOST

- **Rooms with ugly or excessive woodwork.** Boxed-in pipes, a radiator, four doors, a fuse box. Painting all of it out is the only cheap fix that genuinely works.
- **Small rooms and awkward shapes.** Attic rooms with sloping ceilings, box rooms, under-stair spaces.
- **Hallways**, which are almost entirely made of junctions.

HOW TO DO IT PROPERLY

Use **one colour in different finishes**, not one finish everywhere: matt on the walls and ceiling, eggshell or satin on the woodwork. The colour reads as continuous, but the woodwork is durable and washable, and the slight difference in sheen gives the room a subtle life that a single flat finish does not have. Page 67 covers sheens.

WHY THIS IS NOT JUST A TREND

Before white paint was cheap, rooms were routinely finished in one colour throughout, because mixing several was expensive. What looks like a bold modern choice is mostly a return to the ordinary.

Skirtings, architraves and doors

Woodwork is white because woodwork is white. It is the same unexamined default as the ceiling, and it is doing more harm in more rooms.

Add up the woodwork in an ordinary room: skirting all the way round, architrave round the door and the window, the door itself, perhaps a picture rail. It is a considerable area, and in most homes it is painted the brightest white in the house, in the shiniest finish in the house, outlining every edge of the room in high contrast.

THE FOUR OPTIONS, FROM QUIETEST TO LOUDEST

- 1 **The same colour as the walls.** Everything disappears. See the previous page. The best answer in most small and awkward rooms.
- 2 **A shade or two deeper than the walls, same colour family.** The woodwork reads as a soft frame rather than a bright outline. Elegant, easy, and almost impossible to get wrong.
- 3 **A soft white or greige rather than brilliant white.** If you want the contrast of white woodwork without the glare. This is the standard decorator's answer and it suits period rooms with good mouldings that deserve to be seen.
- 4 **A deliberately contrasting colour.** A deep green skirting under pale walls, a black door. A real move with real presence, and the one most likely to go wrong. Commit to it across the whole room or it looks like an unfinished job.

THE DOOR IS WORTH ITS OWN THOUGHT

A door is a large flat rectangle at eye level, and painting it the wall colour makes it vanish — which is usually what you want in a small room with several doors. Painting it a deep colour when the walls are pale makes it an object, which is worth doing when the door is handsome and there is only one of them.

OLD PAINT, AND PLEASE READ THIS ONE

Woodwork in older buildings can carry many layers. In the United States, lead-based paint was banned for residential use in 1978; other countries have their own dates, generally in the same era. Sanding old woodwork is what makes lead dangerous, because it puts it into the air. If your building predates that and you are planning to sand woodwork back, get the paint tested first. This is not a job to guess at, and it is the one place in this book where I would rather you did nothing than proceed uncertain.

The accent wall, properly examined

I dismissed this in one paragraph on page 20. It is common enough to deserve the full argument, and there is a version that works.

WHAT GOES WRONG

- **It shortens the room.** A darker surface is read by the eye as nearer. Paint one wall dark and three pale, and the room appears shorter in that direction. People almost always paint the far wall, and the far wall is the one whose distance they were hoping to increase.
- **It divides rather than transforms.** The room now has two characters and a hard line between them, and the line is the thing you see.
- **It is often the window wall,** which is the worst choice available: you have put your darkest surface immediately around your only light source, so the contrast between the bright window and the dark wall is at its most severe and the room reads as gloomy.
- **The junctions get worse, not better.** Now there are two colours meeting at two corners, plus white woodwork, plus a white ceiling. More edges, not fewer.

THE VERSION THAT WORKS

Not an accent wall — an **accent volume**. Take the colour round an entire part of the room that is architecturally separate: an alcove and the shelves in it, a chimney breast including its returns, the inside of a bookcase, a bay, a small connected room seen through a doorway.

The difference is that you are colouring a *thing* rather than a surface. An alcove painted deep green is an alcove. The far wall painted deep green is a wall that has been painted a different colour from the other three.

THE TEST BEFORE YOU PAINT ONE WALL

Ask whether the surface you are about to colour is a thing or a side. Paint things. Leave sides alone.

And if what you actually want is for the room to feel different — the thing an accent wall promises — the answer is on page 62. One colour on all four walls and the ceiling changes a room far more than one wall in five ever will, and takes about the same amount of paint.

Sheen, which is half the decision

Two tins of the identical colour in different finishes are two different colours on the wall. Sheen is not a detail at the end of the process; it changes what you see.

Sheen is how much light a finish reflects directly back at you rather than scattering it. A flat finish scatters almost everything, so the colour looks deep, soft and even. A gloss finish bounces a good deal straight back, so the colour looks lighter, harder and more variable depending on where you stand.

THE TRADE YOU ARE MAKING, IN ONE LINE

THE SHEEN TRADE

More sheen is more washable and more durable. Less sheen is more beautiful and hides more. Choose by how much the surface gets touched.

THE FIVE LEVELS

FINISH	LOOKS	HIDES FLAWS	WIPES CLEAN
Flat / matt	Deepest colour, velvety, no reflection at all	Best	Poorly — can burnish if scrubbed
Matt emulsion	Soft, very slight sheen	Very well	Gently
Eggshell	Low sheen, slightly luminous	Moderately	Well
Satin	Noticeable sheen, colour lifts	Poorly	Very well
Gloss	Mirror-like, shows every ripple	Not at all	Best

THE ONE THAT CATCHES PEOPLE OUT

A colour in satin or gloss will read **lighter** than the same colour in matt, because more light is coming straight back to your eye. If you test in matt and buy in satin you will not get the colour you chose. Test in the finish you intend to use.

And a practical warning about deep colours in matt: they are the most beautiful finish in this table and the least repairable. A scuff cannot simply be wiped, and a touch-up patch will often show unless you re-coat the whole wall. Lovely in a sitting room. Not in a hallway with a bicycle in it.

Which sheen, where

The whole of the last page as a table. This is the one to photograph before you go to the shop.

SURFACE	USE	WHY
Sitting room and bedroom walls	Matt	Deepest colour, hides plaster, rarely touched
Ceilings, everywhere	Flat or matt	Any sheen overhead catches the light and shows every roller line
Hallway and stair walls	Matt emulsion or eggshell	Hands, bags, bicycles. Needs to survive wiping
Kitchen walls	Eggshell or satin	Grease and steam. Must wash
Bathroom walls	Eggshell or a bathroom-specific matt	Moisture. A flat finish will not survive it
Skirting, architrave, doors	Eggshell or satin	Kicked, knocked, cleaned. Needs a hard film
Windowsills	Satin or gloss	Hardest wear and most moisture in the room
Radiators	Eggshell or satin , radiator-grade	Ordinary paint yellows with heat
A room with bad plaster	Flat, always	Sheen is what reveals an uneven surface

THE RULE UNDER THE TABLE

Work out how often a hand touches the surface. Never touched: matt. Touched weekly: eggshell. Touched daily or wet: satin. That single question answers nine of these ten rows without the table.

ONE HONEST EFFICIENCY

You do not need five tins. For most flats, **two** is genuinely enough: matt for walls and ceilings, eggshell for all woodwork. Add a satin only if you have a wet room or a hallway that takes real punishment. The five-level table exists so you know what you are choosing between, not so you buy all of it.

A USEFUL STORY

The most copied French colour is a mistake

There is a grey that the design world has been copying for two hundred years, and restoration has now established that it was never the original colour at all.

It is called *gris Trianon* — Trianon grey. It appears as a named court colour in Versailles inventory documents of the 1770s and 1780s, and it is associated with the Temple of Love at the Petit Trianon, the small palace in the grounds of Versailles. It is a soft dove grey that reads almost as cement in poor light and as a pale barley-taupe in good light, and if you have ever seen a photograph of a beautiful French room with grey panelling, you have seen its descendants.

What restoration work at the Trianon has revealed is that the famous grey is a **nineteenth-century repaint**. Underneath it, the original finish was a pale green.

So the colour that the whole world understands as the authentic colour of eighteenth-century French elegance is a Victorian decorator's decision, applied over the real thing, and copied ever since by people who believed they were being faithful.

WHY I PUT THIS IN A BOOK ABOUT YOUR FLAT

There is no authentic colour to be faithful to. There is only what works in the light you have.

AND IT IS STILL A VERY GOOD GREY

That is the other half of the point. Knowing it is a repaint does not make it worse. It is a warm grey with enough green in it to stay soft under electric light, which is exactly why it has survived two centuries of copying — it behaves well. The nineteenth-century decorator who chose it knew what they were doing.

If you want a grey that does not go cold at night, look for one with a trace of green rather than blue in it. That is the whole technical content of this famous colour, and it costs nothing to apply.

OLD WALLS

Badigeon à la chaux — limewash

If your building is old and has solid walls, this page may save you a great deal of trouble, and it is the one my father would have wanted in the book.

Limewash is one of the oldest wall finishes there is — lime finishes go back to Greek and Roman building. It is made of three things: slaked lime, water, and natural pigment. That is the whole recipe. It dries to a chalky, matte, faintly variegated surface with a quality of depth that modern paint cannot reproduce, because you are looking slightly *into* it rather than at a film on top.

THE PROPERTY THAT MATTERS MORE THAN THE LOOK

Limewash is **breathable**. It is porous, so moisture in a wall can pass through it and evaporate away.

Old buildings with solid walls and no damp-proof course are designed to work this way. They take up moisture and release it again, constantly, and they stay sound as long as nothing stops them. A modern plastic-based paint forms an impermeable film, which traps that moisture in the wall. The result is damp that appears after redecorating, blown plaster, and paint that lifts off in sheets — and the owner concludes the wall has a damp problem, when what it has is a paint problem.

TWO REAL CAUTIONS

Wet lime is **caustic**. It has a very high pH and it will burn skin and eyes. Gloves and eye protection, every time, and this is not a place to be relaxed about it.

And limewash will not adhere to a wall that is already covered in modern emulsion. It needs a porous surface — bare plaster, lime plaster, brick or stone. Painting it over vinyl emulsion will simply produce dust.

WHO THIS IS ACTUALLY FOR

If you live in a modern building with plasterboard walls, none of this applies to you and ordinary paint is correct. If you live in something old with thick solid walls, it is worth finding out what is already on them before you add another layer, because the wrong finish on an old wall is a slow and expensive mistake.

How many colours a home should have

Fewer than you think, and repeated more than you think. This is the page that makes a flat feel like one home rather than a series of decisions.

THE WORKING SCHEME

- 1 **One white.** The same white on every ceiling and every piece of woodwork in the flat, unless a room is being drenched in its own colour. One tin, one decision, permanent consistency.
- 2 **One quiet colour** that carries the circulation — hall, landing, stairs, and any room you have not made a specific decision about. This is the flat's ground note.
- 3 **Two or three room colours**, each belonging to a room with a distinct character. The bedroom, the sitting room, perhaps a study or dining room.
- 4 **One deeper accent** that appears in small quantities across several rooms — a door, an alcove, a bookcase interior. This is the thread that stitches the flat together.

Five or six colours for a whole home. Most flats I have worked in had eleven or twelve, all chosen separately, none of them wrong, and the whole never adding up.

WHY REPETITION MATTERS MORE THAN VARIETY

A colour used once is a decoration. The same colour used three times in three rooms is a scheme.

THE DOORWAY TEST

Stand in any doorway where you can see into two rooms at once, which in most flats is the hall. Everything visible from that spot has to agree, because you will see it together several times a day.

This is where the undertone rule from page 50 does its real work: not within a room, but across a threshold. Two rooms that are lovely on their own and disagree at the doorway is the commonest whole-flat error there is, and it is invisible until you go and stand there.

And the practical benefit: one white and one circulation colour means you own two large tins that cover nine-tenths of the surfaces in the flat. Touching up becomes trivial, and it costs less.

The floor has already voted

The largest continuous surface in your home is the one you almost certainly cannot change. Every colour decision above it is a response to it, whether you meant it to be or not.

A floor is typically a quarter of the visible surface of a room, it runs under everything, and it is lit from above all day, which means it is bouncing its own colour onto the bottom of everything in the room. A warm honey oak floor is putting a warm cast on your walls continuously.

READ THE FLOOR FIRST

FLOOR	HAS DECIDED	WORK WITH
Honey or golden oak	warm, quite strongly	warm whites, greige, olive and moss greens, warm browns
Mid brown, walnut	warm, moderately	almost anything warm; very forgiving
Grey or limed timber	cool	cool whites, blue-greys, sage
Red-toned timber or terracotta	warm, very strongly	creams, olive, deep green; avoid pink-beige entirely
Grey tile or concrete	cool	cool or neutral; add warmth in textiles instead
Mid-grey carpet	usually cool, check it	run the paper test on the carpet — many read violet

IF YOU ARE FIGHTING THE FLOOR

You will lose. A cool grey wall above an orange-toned floor is a fight that happens in every room of the flat, all day, and no amount of styling settles it. The honest options are to work with the floor's temperature, to cover a good deal of it with a rug in your chosen temperature, or to change the floor — which is expensive and is the only place in this book where I would say the expensive answer is often correct.

THE FLOOR RUNS THROUGH

One continuous floor through connected rooms makes a small flat read as one home. A change of flooring at every threshold chops it into cupboards.

This is mine and it is about layout as much as colour. If you are ever in a position to choose flooring for more than one room, choose the same one and run it through. It is the single most effective thing you can do to make a small flat feel generous.

Matching is a trap

The instinct, once you have chosen a wall colour, is to find a cushion in the same colour. Resist it. Matching is what makes a room look like it came in a box.

Two things prevent an exact match from ever working. The first is that the same colour in two different materials is not the same colour — paint on plaster and dye in wool reflect light completely differently, so a perfect match on paper reads as a near-miss in the room, and a near-miss is worse than a difference. The second is that a room where everything agrees exactly has nothing for the eye to do.

WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

- **Stay in the family, change the depth.** If the walls are a soft green, the cushions can be a much deeper green or a much paler one. Same undertone, different value. This always works.
- **Repeat the colour in a different material.** The wall colour appearing again in a ceramic, a book spine, a painting — small, and in something with a different surface. The eye enjoys finding it.
- **Let one thing disagree on purpose.** A room that is entirely harmonious is slightly dead. One object in a colour that has no relationship to the scheme is what stops it feeling assembled.

THE ONE THING THAT GENUINELY SHOULD MATCH

Whites. If you have white woodwork, white ceilings and white curtains, those *should* be the same white or obviously different whites, never nearly-the-same whites. Near-misses in white read as dirt. This is the exception to everything on this page.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

My grandmother would not sell a client a fabric that matched their wall. She said a room should look as though it had been arrived at over years, not delivered on a Tuesday. She had been making curtains for thirty years by then and could afford to say so.

Colour when you cannot paint

Part Six is written entirely for rented rooms. This page is the colour half of it, because everything above assumes a paintbrush you may not be allowed to pick up.

FIRST, CHECK WHETHER YOU ACTUALLY CANNOT

A great many tenancies permit redecoration with written permission, and a landlord who has a white magnolia flat is often perfectly happy for you to improve it at your own cost if you agree to return it to neutral. It is worth one email. The worst answer is no, which is where you are already.

IF THE ANSWER IS NO, THE ORDER CHANGES

Without paint, the largest colour surfaces available to you are, in order of area:

- 1 **Curtains.** Floor to near-ceiling, across a whole wall, in a colour you chose. This is by a wide margin the biggest colour decision available to a tenant, and Part Four covers how to hang them so they read as architecture rather than as fabric.
- 2 **A large rug.** The second largest surface, and the one that can override an unpleasant floor's temperature. Bigger than feels sensible — page 94.
- 3 **The bed, in a bedroom.** A bed dressed in one considered colour is most of the visual field in a small bedroom.
- 4 **Bookcases and their contents,** which are a wall of colour you already own.
- 5 **Large art or a hanging textile.** One big thing beats six small ones.

THE WHITE-WALL STRATEGY

If you are stuck with landlord white, stop treating it as a background to improve and start treating it as a gallery wall. White walls are genuinely excellent behind strong colour and strong texture — it is only as a whole scheme that they fail. Go deeper and warmer in everything you can control, and let the walls be the quiet part.

ONE THING WORTH KNOWING

Magnolia and builder's white are usually a cheap vinyl matt, which marks easily and cleans badly. If you are allowed to repaint before you leave, budget for it — a flat returned in fresh white is often the difference between getting a deposit back and arguing about it.

MISTAKES TO AVOID

The six colour errors I saw most often

ONE · CHOOSING THE COLOUR BEFORE FIXING THE LIGHT

The error this whole book is ordered around. You choose for a light you are about to change, and then you have chosen wrong. Bulbs first, always — it is an afternoon and it decides everything.

TWO · TESTING ON THE WALL INSTEAD OF ON PAPER

A patch painted on an existing wall is judged against that wall, and the old colour around it biases everything you see. It also means you cannot move it to the dark corner, which is the position that matters most.

THREE · TWO WHITES THAT ARE NEARLY THE SAME

Ceiling in one white, woodwork in another, walls in a third, none of them chosen together. The eye cannot read the difference as a decision so it reads it as dirt. One white through the whole flat solves it permanently.

FOUR · THE MID-TONE COMPROMISE

Page 59. Choosing something halfway between pale and deep because it feels like the sensible option gets you the disadvantages of both. Commit in one direction.

FIVE · IGNORING WHAT IS OUTSIDE THE WINDOW

A large tree throws green light into a room from spring to autumn. A red brick wall a few metres away throws warm light in all year. Both will shift a wall colour more than the compass direction does, and neither shows up on any paint card.

SIX · BUYING THE PAINT BEFORE THE SHEETS HAVE BEEN UP TWO DAYS

Because the shop is open now and the weekend is free. This is how almost every repainted room happens. The two days cost nothing and they are the entire method.

WHAT ALL SIX HAVE IN COMMON

Not one of them is a mistake of taste. Every one is a mistake of sequence — deciding something before the thing it depends on was settled.

TROUBLESHOOTING

“I painted it and I hate it”

Before you repaint, work out which of these it is. Three of the five are not solved by a different colour, and repainting would waste a weekend.

IT LOOKS MUCH DARKER THAN THE SAMPLE

Expected, and usually not a colour problem. A whole room reads deeper than a sample because light bounces between the walls, each bounce deepening it. Give it a week before you judge — your eye adapts considerably. If it is still too much, the fix is often lighting, not paint: the room may simply have gone dark, which is page 58.

IT LOOKED FINE BY DAY AND IS HORRIBLE AT NIGHT

A bulb problem, not a paint problem. You have almost certainly got mixed colour temperatures or bulbs above 3000 K. Change every bulb in the room to 2700 K, with a CRI of 90 or above, and look again the following evening. This fixes it far more often than repainting does.

IT HAS GONE A COMPLETELY DIFFERENT COLOUR FROM THE SAMPLE

Check three things in order: whether the finish differs from what you tested (satin reads lighter than matt), whether it has had two full coats, and whether the wall underneath was a strong colour showing through. A deep colour over a dark wall can need three coats before it is itself.

IT IS FINE BUT IT FIGHTS THE FLOOR OR THE SOFA

An undertone clash, page 50. Nothing is wrong with the colour and repainting in the same family will not help. Either change the smaller thing, or put a rug between them in a colour that belongs to both.

IT IS SIMPLY FLAT AND LIFELESS

Usually not colour at all. Check the four textures on page 10 and the three lighting heights on page 28. A correct colour in a one-texture room lit from the ceiling will always look dead, and painting it a second colour will not change that.

BEFORE YOU REPAINT ANYTHING

Live with it for two weeks. Colour adaptation is real and substantial — a room that feels overwhelming on day one often feels correct by day ten. I have talked more people out of repainting than into it, and almost none of them came back.

The order of painting a room

Not a decorating manual — there are good ones and this is not trying to be one. But the sequence saves a day and almost nobody is told it.

- 1 **Empty the room, or as near as you can get.** Everything into the middle, covered. The time you spend here you get back twice in not working around things.
- 2 **Fill, sand, and wash the walls.** Fill every hole including the ones you are about to make again. Sugar soap or a cloth and warm water on anything greasy, especially above a radiator and around light switches, because paint does not stick to grease.
- 3 **Ceiling first.** Always. It spatters, and everything below it will be painted afterwards.
- 4 **Walls second.**
- 5 **Woodwork last.** Skirting, architrave, doors, windows. Woodwork paint is slower, more precise, and the thing you most want to avoid rushing — so it goes when nothing else is waiting on it.
- 6 **Two coats of everything.** Including the thing you think looks fine after one. A single coat on a wall reads patchy in raking light for as long as you live there.

THE TWO THINGS WORTH SPENDING MONEY ON

- **A decent brush** for the woodwork and the cutting-in. A cheap brush sheds bristles into the wet paint and leaves a visibly worse edge, and you will be looking at that edge every day.
- **Enough paint.** Running out two-thirds of the way through a wall and finishing from a second tin mixed at a different time is how you get a visible join. Buy the whole quantity at once, and if it is a mixed colour, check the tins are from the same batch.

VENTILATION, AND THE ONE REAL HAZARD

Keep windows open and the room aired while you paint and for a day after. If the building predates the late 1970s and you intend to *sand* old paintwork rather than just paint over it, stop and read page 63 first — sanding is what makes old lead paint dangerous.

A WORKED EXAMPLE

One room, from start to finish

This is a constructed example, written to show the method applied end to end. It is not a real client.

THE ROOM

A sitting room of about sixteen square metres in a 1930s flat. One window facing north-east, used mostly in the evenings. Honey oak floorboards. A mid-grey sofa. Landlord white walls, a brilliant white ceiling, white woodwork, and one ceiling pendant with a 4000 K bulb in it. The owner described it as “fine but depressing” and wanted to paint it a pale grey.

THE AUDIT

- **Light:** one source, one height, cool bulb. Error one, plus the wrong colour temperature.
- **Height:** pictures centred at about 122 cm, curtain pole 4 cm above the frame, curtains 6 cm off the floor. Error two, comprehensively.
- **Texture:** fabric sofa, fabric curtain, fabric cushions, painted surfaces. Two families. Error three.
- **Ceiling:** brilliant white, never considered. Error four.
- **Orientation:** north-east, used in the evening — so, per page 26, decorate it as a north room.

WHAT WAS DONE, IN ORDER

- 1 Every bulb changed to 2700 K, CRI 90. Two lamps added — one at 105 cm on a side table, one on the floor behind a chair. The pendant now stays off in the evening.
- 2 Curtain pole moved to 12 cm below the ceiling and widened so the curtains stack on the wall. Curtains re-hung to the floor. Pictures re-hung to 145 cm.
- 3 Only then, colour. The proposed pale grey was tested and abandoned: it went violet under the new warm bulbs and fought the honey floor. A soft warm white was chosen for the walls, the same white at quarter strength for the ceiling, and eggshell in the same white for the woodwork.
- 4 A wool rug in a deep olive, an oak stool, and a large unglazed pot. Four textures.

THE POINT OF THE EXAMPLE

The owner asked for a colour. Colour was the fourth thing done, it was not the colour requested, and the largest single change in the room was two lamps and a packet of bulbs.

WORKSHEET

The paint schedule for a whole home

One sheet for the flat, not one per room. That is the point of it — page 69.

THE SCHEME

THE ONE WHITE (ALL CEILINGS + WOODWORK)

WARM OR COOL, FOR THE WHOLE FLAT

THE CIRCULATION COLOUR (HALL, LANDING, STAIRS)

THE DEEPER ACCENT (DOORS, ALCOVES, SHELVES)

ROOM BY ROOM

ROOM	FACES	WALL COLOUR	CEILING	WOODWORK	SHEEN

THE WHOLE-FLAT CHECKS

- ☐ Six colours or fewer across the entire home
- ☐ One white on every ceiling and every piece of woodwork
- ☐ Every colour is on the same side, warm or cool
- ☐ I stood in the hall doorway and everything visible agrees
- ☐ The accent colour appears in at least three places
- ☐ Every colour was tested on paper, in its room, at four hours
- ☐ Bulbs were changed to 2700 K before any colour was chosen

WHAT NOT TO BUY

Paint and colour

A COLOUR FAN DECK

Two thousand chips makes the decision harder, not easier, and every one of them is printed ink viewed under shop light. You need three candidates and two sheets of paper. The fan is a merchandising object.

“ONE COAT” PAINT

It is thicker, it costs more, and it still wants two coats to look even in raking light. You are paying a premium for a claim you will not act on.

PAINT-AND-PRIMER-IN-ONE, FOR A NORMAL REPAINT

Genuinely useful on bare plaster, new plasterboard or a drastic colour change. Painting a similar colour over sound existing paint, which is most repaints, does not need it.

PEEL-AND-STICK WALLPAPER AS A CURE FOR RENTED WHITE

Sold directly at tenants and it is a recurring purchase dressed as a solution. It is expensive per square metre, it is difficult to hang without visible seams, it frequently does not survive removal without taking paint with it, and it solves a problem that curtains and a rug solve better and cheaper. Page 72.

A COLOUR CONSULTATION THAT ARRIVES WITHOUT SEEING YOUR ROOM

Anybody choosing your colours from photographs is guessing, because a photograph has an automatic white balance and has already destroyed the information about your light. If you pay for advice, pay for someone who stands in the room at the hour you use it.

TESTER POTS IN MORE THAN THREE COLOURS

Buying eight is a symptom of not having narrowed the decision. Do the orientation table on page 55, get to three, and test those properly.

WHAT TO BUY INSTEAD

Three sample pots. Four large sheets of paper. One good brush. Enough paint for two coats, in one batch. That is the entire shopping list for a room, and it is less than most people spend on the things above.

THE QUIET PART

Who profits from the colour of the year

Every autumn, several large paint companies announce a colour of the year. It is reported as news. It is worth looking at what it is for.

A colour of the year does two things at once. It gives magazines and shops something to write about and arrange displays around, which is ordinary commerce and nobody's business but theirs. And it establishes, by implication, that there is a colour which is *current* — which necessarily means the colour on your walls is last year's.

That is the whole mechanism. Paint does not wear out. A well-painted wall in a room nobody kicks will look perfectly good in fifteen years. So an industry selling a product that does not expire has to supply a reason to replace it, and taste is the only reason available.

Nobody decided this in a room somewhere. It is quieter and sadder than that.

There is no money in telling you that the soft warm white you chose three years ago, for the north-facing room you still live in, is still exactly the right colour for it. There is a great deal of money in a calendar that quietly makes every room in the country a year out of date each October. Not one person has to intend it for that to be how the whole thing works.

THE TEST THAT SURVIVES ANY TREND

A colour chosen for the direction your window faces cannot go out of fashion, because your window will not move.

WHAT THIS IS NOT

It is not an argument that the paint companies make bad paint. They make very good paint, the colours in their ranges are carefully developed, and the LRV figure on the card is one of the most useful pieces of information in this whole subject. Use the product. Ignore the calendar.

And if you like this year's colour — genuinely like it, in your own room, at dusk, under your own lamps — then paint your room with it. Liking something is a perfectly good reason. Being told it is current is not.

QUESTIONS I AM ASKED

Eight short answers

CAN I PAINT OVER WALLPAPER?

Sometimes, if it is sound, well stuck and not textured or vinyl. Test a small area first — paint wets the paste and can lift a seam. If any edge is loose, it will get worse. Stripping is more work and the right answer more often.

DO I NEED TO PRIME?

Bare plaster, new plasterboard, bare wood or a drastic colour change: yes. Sound existing paint in a similar colour: no.

HOW MUCH PAINT WILL I NEED?

Measure the walls and check the tin, because coverage varies by brand and colour. Then buy somewhat more than the tin claims. Deep colours and porous surfaces both drink more, and running out mid-wall is the one thing you cannot recover from neatly.

IS EXPENSIVE PAINT WORTH IT?

Often, for a deep colour, where the pigment load genuinely shows in depth and coverage and may save you a coat. Much less so for a white ceiling. Spend on the colour that people will look at and economise on the ones they will not.

CAN I USE EXTERIOR PAINT INSIDE?

No. It is formulated for weather and flexibility rather than for scrubbing and low odour, and some exterior products are not intended for enclosed spaces. Buy the right one.

WHAT ABOUT A RADIATOR?

Use a radiator-grade paint; ordinary white paint yellows with heat. Paint it cold, and leave it a good while before turning the heating on.

SHOULD THE INSIDE OF MY FRONT DOOR MATCH THE OUTSIDE?

No, and it almost never should. The inside belongs to the hall's scheme, the outside belongs to the street. They are two different rooms.

DOES A DARK CEILING REALLY MAKE A ROOM FEEL LOWER?

It makes it feel *closer*, which in a high room reads as intimate and in a low room reads as oppressive. Page 61. Above roughly two point seven metres it is an option worth having; below that, be careful.

THE HONEST PART

Where I might be wrong

I will not sell you a fantasy, and that is the whole reason you can trust the rest of this. Four places where what I have told you is opinion, or is limited, or where I know good decorators who disagree with me.

THE SMALL PALE ROOM

Page 57 is my most contested position and I have marked it as mine throughout. Plenty of excellent designers hold the opposite view and produce beautiful pale small rooms. What I will defend without hesitation is the narrower claim: *brilliant* white in a small dark room is a mistake. The argument about pale versus deep is a real argument.

THE WHOLE BOOK ASSUMES THE NORTHERN HEMISPHERE

Every orientation rule in Parts Two and Three assumes you are north of the equator. South of it, swap north and south and leave east and west as they are. Near the equator the whole framework weakens, because the sun passes much closer to overhead and the differences between orientations narrow considerably.

LRV BANDS ARE GUIDANCE, NOT A STANDARD

The numbers on page 59 are working ranges I use, not an industry classification. A saturated mid-tone in a well-lit south room can be excellent and would fall squarely in the band I called a trap. Use them to compare candidates, not to rule one out.

SOMETIMES THE EXPENSIVE ANSWER IS THE RIGHT ONE

I have spent this part explaining how to avoid wasting money on paint. But if your floor is fighting every colour in the flat, page 70, the honest answer is that changing the floor is the real fix and no amount of clever colour work substitutes for it. I would rather say so than sell you a workaround that leaves you dissatisfied for ten years.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

My father would not let a client thank him for a colour until they had lived with it through one full change of season. He said anybody can be pleased in October.

WORKSHEET

The colour audit

For a room you have already decorated and are not happy with. Run it before you decide to repaint — page 74.

ROOM

WHAT SPECIFICALLY BOTHERS ME

FIRST, RULE OUT THE THINGS THAT ARE NOT COLOUR

- ☐ Every bulb in this room is 2700 K
- ☐ Every bulb in this room is the *same* colour temperature
- ☐ Light arrives at three heights
- ☐ Four texture families are present
- ☐ Nothing is hung below 145 cm to its centre

If any box is unticked, fix that first. More than half the rooms brought to me as colour problems were not colour problems.

THEN THE COLOUR ITSELF

SURFACE

COLOUR

WARM OR COOL?

Walls

Ceiling

Woodwork

Floor

Largest fabric

Curtain

- ☐ Every row above is on the same side, warm or cool
- ☐ There is only one white in this room
- ☐ The wall colour agrees with the floor's temperature

THE ODD ONE OUT — AND IS IT CHEAPER TO CHANGE THAN THE WALLS?

The colour weekend

If you have read this far and want a plan rather than a philosophy, here it is. Two weekends and one week of waiting in between.

WEEKEND ONE — ABOUT TWO HOURS OF ACTUAL WORK

- 1 **Change every bulb in the room to 2700 K.** Before anything else, so that every judgement afterwards is made in the light you will keep.
- 2 **Find your orientation** and write it down. Page 23.
- 3 **Decide warm or cool for the whole flat,** by looking at the floor. Page 70.
- 4 **Narrow to three candidates** using the table on page 55, and buy three sample pots and four large sheets of paper.
- 5 **Paint the sheets, two coats,** and tape them up in three positions.

THE WEEK IN BETWEEN

Do nothing. Look at the sheets in passing — morning, midday, dusk, and at night under the lamps. Move them once, halfway through. Let one colour lose.

WEEKEND TWO

- 1 **Fill, sand, wash.** Every hole, including the ones you will re-drill.
- 2 **Ceiling, walls, woodwork,** in that order, two coats of each. Page 75.
- 3 **Re-hang at the right heights** while the walls are empty and you have the ladder out — pictures to 145 cm, the curtain pole as high and as wide as it will go. Part Four.
- 4 **Put back less than you took out.**

THE ONE THAT IS NOT OPTIONAL

Change the bulbs on the first morning, before you look at a single colour. Every other step in this plan depends on it.

And do one room. Not the flat. Finish it, live in it for a month, and you will make much better decisions about the second room than you could possibly make today.

Part Three, in ten lines

ONE

Colour is not a property of paint. It is what happens when that paint meets the light in your room.

TWO

You do not need to know which undertone a room has. You need all of them to be the same one.

THREE

A colour chosen for the direction your window faces cannot go out of fashion, because your window will not move.

AND THE SEVEN THAT DO NOT NEED THEIR OWN PAGE

- **Paint the paper, not the wall,** and move it round the room for two days. Four viewings: morning, midday, dusk, lamps only.
- **A chip cannot tell you anything.** Use it to get from fifty colours to three, then stop using it.
- **If two colours survive, take the paler one.** Every colour deepens once it covers a whole room.
- **Commit in one direction.** Pale or deep. The mid-tone buys the costs of both and the benefits of neither.
- **One white for the whole flat.** Two nearly-identical whites read as dirt, not as a decision.
- **Choose the sheen by how often a hand touches the surface.** Never: matt. Weekly: eggshell. Daily or wet: satin.
- **Paint things, not sides.** An alcove, a chimney breast, a bookcase. Never one wall out of four.

NEXT

Part Four is height and proportion — the curtain pole, the picture hook, the rug that is too small. It is the part with the most numbers in it and the fastest visible results, and half of it costs nothing at all.

Change the bulbs. Wait two days. Then choose. That is Part Three.